

Chapter 1

A Way Can Be a Guide
A way can be a guide, but not a fixed path; names can be given, but not permanent labels. Nonbeing is called the beginning of heaven and earth; being is called the mother of all things. Always passi

The principle that can be enunciated is not the one that always was. The being that can be named is not the one that was at all times. Before time there was an ineffable, unnameable being. When it was still unnameable, it conceived heav

Words and names are not the way They can't define the absolute It's better that you look within Hold your tongue and just be mute Look within and look out too You will not find a separation Out there you see appearance Within

The Tao that can be told of is not the eternal Tao; The name that can be named is not the eternal name. The Nameless is the origin of Heaven and Earth; The Named is the mother of all things. Therefore let there always be non-being, so we may see the

onless, thereby observe the subtle; ever intent, thereby observe the apparent. These two come from the same source but differ in name; both are considered mysteries. The mystery of mysteries is the gateway of marvels. up

en and earth. When it had thus become nameable, it gave birth to the multitude of beings. These two acts are but one, under two different denominations. The unique act of generation; that is the mystery of the beginning; the effects. up

you see origination Look within with wonder At emptiness and bliss For wonder names totality Where nothing is amiss The space within is always there If you can moderate desire A place of utter emptiness And possibility entire

ir subtlety, And let there always be being, so we may see their outcome. The two are the same, But after they are produced, they have different names. They both may be called deep and profound. Deeper and more profound, The door to all subtleties! up

Chapter 2

Everyone Knows
When everyone
knows beauty is
beauty, this is bad.
When everyone
knows good is
good, this is not
good. So being
and nonbeing
produce each
other: difficulty and
ease complement
each other, long
and short shape
each other, high
and low contrast
with each other,
voice and echoes
conform to e

Everyone has the
idea of beauty,
and from that by
opposition that of
not beautiful
(ugly). All men
have the idea of
good, and from
that by contrast
that of not good
(bad). Thus, being
and nothingness,
difficult and easy,
long and short,
high and low,
sound and tone,
before and after,
are correlative
ideas, one of
which, in being
know

Where beautiful
and ugly Do not
stand in
opposition
Where life and
death or yes and
no Do not make
a contradiction
Can you see the
vacant place
Where good and
bad and sad and
mer

ach other, before
and after go along
with each other.
So sages manage
effortless service
and carry out
unspoken
guidance. All
beings work,
without exception:
if they live without
possessiveness,
act without
presumption, and
do not dwell on
success, then by
this very
nondwelling
success will not
leave. up

n, reveals the
other. That being
so, the Sage
serves without
acting and teaches
without speaking.
He lets all beings
become, without
thwarting them, he
lets them live,
without
monopolizing
them, and lets
them act, without
exploiting them.
He does not
attribute to himself
the effects
produced, and in
consequence
these effects last.
up

ry Disappear
forevermore?
Where nothing
ever is contrary
So stay within
the emptiness
Unless you rise
you never fall
Accepting that
which comes
your way You
are forever all in
all

ch other.
Therefore the sage
manages affairs
without action And
spreads doctrines
without words. All
things arise, and
he does not turn
away from them.
He produces them
but does not take
possession of
them. He acts but
does not rely on
his own ability. He
accomplishes his
task but does not
claim credit for it. It
is precisely
because he does
not claim credit
that his
accomplishment
remains with him.
up

Chapter 3

Not Exalting
Cleverness Not
exalting
cleverness causes
the people not to
contend. Not
putting high prices
on hard-to-get
goods causes the
people not to steal.
Not seeing
anything to want
causes the mind
not to be
confused.
Therefore the
government of s

Not making any
special case of
cleverness, of
ability, will have
the result that
people will no
longer push
themselves. Not to
prize rare objects
will have the result
that no one will
continue to steal.
To show nothing
as alluring will
have the effect of
putting the
people's hearts at
rest. Therefore the
politics of Sages
consis

If you love
accumulation
Gain and
increase every
day Thieves and
robbers will be
waiting Just to
take it all away
Best t

Stop looking for
rare, moral
persons (hsien) to
put in power.
There will be
jealousies among
people, jealousies
and strife. If we
cease to set store
by products that
are hard to get,
there will be less
outright thieves. If
the people never
see such things as
excite desire, their
hearts can remain
placid and
undisturbed.
Therefore the wise
o

Do not exalt the
worthy, so that the
people shall not
compete. Do not
value rare
treasures, so that
the people shall
not steal. Do not
display objects of
desire, so that the
people's hearts
shall not be
disturbed.
Therefore in the
government of the
sage, He keeps

ages empties the
mind and fills the
middle, weakens
the ambition and
strengthens the
bones, always
keeping the people
innocent and
passionless. it
makes the
sophisticated not
dare to contrive;
action being
without
contrivance,
nothing is
disordered. up

ts in emptying the
minds of men and
filling their
stomachs, in
weakening their
initiative and
strengthening their
bones. Their
constant care is to
hold the people in
ignorance and
apathy. They
make things such
that clever people
dare not to act, for
there is nothing
that cannot be
sorted out through
the practice of
non-action. up

o be so
empty-headed
That it seems
you've lost it all
You will know
you're on the
way Though
others say you're
at a stall

ne rules by
emptying their
hearts [like the
clown]. He fills
their bellies,
weakens their
brightness and
toughens their
bones, ever
striving to make
the people without
knowledge. He
sees to it that if
there are any who
are bright and
clever, they dare
not interfere.
Through his
non-do actions all
[such subjection]
runs well [for some
time].

their hearts
vacuous, Fills their
bellies, Weakens
their ambitions,
And strengthens
their bones, He
always causes his
people to be
without knowledge
(cunning) or
desire, And the
crafty to be afraid
to act. By acting
without action, all
things will be in
order. up

Chapter 4

The Way Is
Unimpeded
Harmony The
Way is
unimpeded
harmony; its
potential may
never be fully
exploited. It is as
deep as the
source of all
things: it blunts
the edges,
resolve

The Principle
produces in
abundance, but
without filling
itself up. Empty
abyss, it seems
to be (is) the
ancestor (origin)
of all beings. It is
peaceful, simple,
modest, amiable.
Spillin

This nothingness
is like a well
Always giving,
never taking And
all claims to
origin Neither
wanting or
forsakin

Dao is like an
empty vessel
that yet can be
drawn from
without ever
needing to be
filled. It's without
bottom; the very
breeder of all
things in the
world. In it all
sharpness is
blunted, all
tangles untied,
all glare tempe

Tao is empty
(like a bowl). It
may be used but
its capacity is
never exhausted
It is bottomless,
perhaps the
ancestor of all
things. It blunts
its sharpness. It
unties its tangles.

s the
complications,
harmonizes the
light, assimilates
to the world.
Profoundly still, it
seems to be
there: I don't
know whose
child it is, before
the creation of
images. up

g itself out in
waves, it seems
to remain (it
remains) always
the same. I do
not know of
whom it is the
son (where it
comes from). It
seems to have
been (it was)
before the
Sovereign. up

g You know it's
ever present You
find it where you
have no face It is
a wondrous
blessing Original
amazing grace

red, all turmoil
smoothed. It's
like a deep pool
that never dries.
Was it too the
child of
something else?
We can hardly
tell. A
substanceless
image of all
things seemed to
exist before the
progenitor that
we hardly know
of.

It softens its light.
It becomes one
with the dusty
world. Deep and
still, it appears to
exist forever. I do
not know whose
son it is. It seems
to have existed
before the Lord.
up

Chapter 5

Heaven and Earth
Heaven and earth are not humane; they regard all beings as straw dogs. Sages are not humane; they see all people as straw dogs. The space between heaven and earth

Heaven and earth are not good to the things that they produce, but treat them like straw dogs. Like heaven and earth, the Sage is not good for the people he governs, but treats them like straw dogs. The betwixt of heaven and earth, seat of the Principle, the place from where its virtue acts, is like a bellows, like the bag of a bellows of whi

This emptiness is truly void And infinitely capacious It holds whatever comes its way Eternally tenacious Can y

The universe seems without mercy, quite ruthless; in that wider perspective all things are but as ritual straw dogs. The wise man too is hard as nail; to him the people are but as straw dogs to throw. Yet heaven and earth and all that lies

Heaven and Earth are not humane. They regard all things as straw dogs. The sage is not humane. He regards all people as straw dogs. How Heaven and Earth are like a b

is like bellows and pipes, empty yet inexhaustible, producing more with movement. The talkative reach their wits' end again and again; that is not as good as keeping centered. up

ch heaven and earth would be the two boards, which empties itself without exhausting itself, which moves itself externally without cease. This is all that we can understand of the Principle and of its action as producer. To seek to detail it further using words and numbers would be a waste of time. Let us hold ourselves to this grand idea. up

ou take whatever comes? Though judgment calls it bad and good Seeing is acceptance And nothing to be understood

between is like a bellows; empty, yet yielding a supply that hardly fails. Work it, and more comes out. Whereas the force of words is soon spent. It seems far better to keep what's in the heart. So hold to the heart core and a regular mean.

ellows. While vacuous, it is never exhausted. When active, it produces even more. Much talk will of course come to a dead end. It is better to keep to the centre. up

Chapter 6

The Valley Spirit
The valley spirit
not dying is
called the
mysterious
female. The
opening of the
mysterious
female is cal

The expansive
transcendent
power which
resides in the
median space,
the virtue of the
Principle, does
not die. It is
always the same
and acts the
same, without
diminution or
cessation. This
virtue is the

Complete and
full awareness Is
like an open
valley Of endless
generation That
doesn't reach
finale I

The valley spirit
never dies. It's
named the
mystic woman.
And the gate of
the profound
woman is the
root that hea

The spirit of the
valley never dies.
It is called the
subtle and
profound female.
The gate of the
subtle and
profound female

led the root of
heaven and
earth.
Continuous, on
the brink of
existence, to put
it into practice,
don't try to force
it. up

mysterious
mother of all
beings. The
doorway of this
mysterious
mother is the
root of heaven
and earth, the
Principle.
Sprouting forth,
she does not
expend herself;
acting, she does
not tire herself.
up

t is a simple
presence It's a
nothing you can
see You'll find it
right at center
Wherever you
may be

ven and earth
sprang from. It's
there within us all
the while; draw
upon it as you
will, you can
never wear it out.

Is the root of
Heaven and
Earth. It is
continuous, and
seems to be
always existing.
Use it and you
will never wear it
out. up

Chapter 7

Heaven Is
Eternal, Earth Is
Everlasting
Heaven is
eternal, earth is
everlasting. The
reason they can
be eternal and
everlasting is
that they do not
foster
themselves; that
is why they can
live for

If heaven and
earth last
forever, it is
because they do
not live for
themselves.
Following this
example, the
Sage, in
withdrawing,

This presence is
unlimited
Because it wasn't
ever born And it
will not be
perishing Will
never give you
cause to mourn It
truly wants for
nothing It has no
wishes of its own
It is the one and
only Eternally
alone It ho

Heaven is always,
the earth, too. How
can it be? Well,
they don't live only
for themselves;
that's why they live
long. So the wise
man puts himself
last, and finds
himself in the
foremost place,
puts himself in the
background; yet
always comes to
the for

Heaven is
eternal and Earth
everlasting. They
can be eternal
and everlasting
because they do
not exist for
themselves, And
for this reason
can exist forever.
Therefore the
sage places
himself in the
back

ever. For this
reason sages put
themselves last,
and they were
first; they
excluded
themselves, and
they survived.
Was it not by
their very
selflessness that
they managed to
fulfill
themselves? up

advances; in
neglecting
himself, he
conserves
himself. As he
does not seek
his own
advantage,
everything turns
to his advantage.
up

Ids itself in
vacancy With no
desire to
advance
Remaining in
simplicity It
merely witnesses
the dance The
seer will remain
behind And
never yearns for
leaving home
Just living in the
here and now
Prefers to stay
unknown

e. He keeps well
fit; looks on his
body almost as
accidental, outer,
something to be
well taken care of;
still it always there,
and always
remains. He
remains in the
open by it, too. He
hardly strives for
great personal
ends; his main
ends seem
fulfilled.

ground but finds
himself in the
foreground. He
puts himself
away, and yet he
always remains.
Is it not because
he has no
personal
interests? This is
the reason why
his personal
interests are
fulfilled. up

Chapter 8

Higher Good Is like Water Higher good is like water: the good in water benefits all, and does so without contention. It rests where people dislike to be, so it is close to the Way. Where it dwells becomes good ground; profound is the go

Transcendent goodness is like water. Water likes to do good to all beings; it does not struggle for any definite form or position, but puts itself in the lowest places that no one wants. By this, it is the reflection of the Principle. From its example, those wh

The seer flows like water Lying low along the way Nourishing whatever comes To be held on display The seer keeps to simple ways And therefore is content When

The highest good is like that of water. The goodness of water is that it benefits the ten thousand creatures; yet itself hardly ever scrambles - it seems quite content with the places that all men disdain. It's this that can make water so near to some dao. And if men think the ground the best place for building a house upon, if among thoughts they valu

The best (man) is like water. Water is good; it benefits all things and does not compete with them. It dwells in (lowly) places that all disdain. This is why it is so near to Tao. (The best man) in his dwelling loves the earth. In his heart, he loves what is pro

od in its heart, benevolent the good it bestows. Goodness in words is trustworthiness, goodness in government is order; goodness in work is ability, goodness in action is timeliness. But only by noncontention is there nothing extreme. up

o imitate the Principle, lower themselves, sink themselves. They are benevolent, sincere, regulated, efficacious, and they conform themselves to the times. They do not struggle for their own interest, but yield. Therefore they do not suffer and contradiction. up

joy or sorrow manifests To give complete assent If you can clearly be yourself And never rise to interfere Everyone will cherish you And always hold you dear

e those that are profound, if in friendship they value gentleness; in words, truth, or sincere faithfulness, in government, [bugbear] order; in deeds: competence, ability, effectiveness; in actions: timeliness and being properly timed - In each case it's because they prefer things that hardly lead to strife, and therefore hardly go much astray or amiss.

found. In his associations, he loves humanity. In his words, he loves faithfulness. In government, he loves order. In handling affairs, he loves competence. In his activities, he loves timeliness. It is because he does not compete that he is without reproach. up

Chapter 9

To Keep on
Filling To keep
on filling Is not as
good as
stopping.
Calculated
sharpness
cannot be kept
for long. Though
gold and jewels
fill their houses,
no one

To hold a vase
filled to the brim,
without spilling
anything, is
impossible; better
not to fill it so. To
keep an
over-sharpened
blade without its
edge becoming
blunt, is
impossible; better
not to sharpen it to
this extreme. To
keep a roomful of
precious stones,
without any of it
becoming
misappropriated, is
impossible;

Don't fill a bowl
Till it's more than
full Or sharpen a
blade Till it must
go dull Don't pile
up treasure That
comes at great c

Stretch a bow to
the full, and you'll
end up wishing
you'd stopped in
time; to hold and
fill to overflowing
isn't quite as able
as to stop in time.
Temper a
sword-edge to its
very sharpest, and
you'll find it soon
grows dull. When
gold and jade fills
your

To hold and fill a
cup to
overflowing Is
not as good as to
stop in time.
Sharpen a sword
edge to its very
sharpest, And
the (edge) will
not last long.
When gold and
jade fill

can keep them.
When the rich
upper classes
are haughty,
their legacy
indicts them.
When one's work
is accomplished
honorably, to
retire is the Way
of heaven. up

better not to
amass this
treasure. No
extreme can be
maintained for a
long time. Every
height is followed
by a decline.
Likewise for a
man.
Whomsoever,
having become
rich and powerful,
takes pride in
himself, prepares
thereby his own
ruin. To retire at
the height of one's
own merit and
fame, that is the
way of heaven. up

ost Approval and
riches Are easily
lost Can you only
do What's really
needed Then
stop and
withdraw When
your task is
completed?

hall, can it be well
guarded any
more? To be
proud with things
and glory given,
could bring ruin.
Wealth and place
breed insolence
and could slowly
harm and ruin: If
your work is done,
withdraw! That's
heaven's way. It
can be opposed to
lots of ways of
man.

your hall, You
will not be able to
keep them. To
be proud with
honour and
wealth Is to
cause one's own
downfall.
withdraw as soon
as your work is
done. Such is
Heaven's Way.
up

Chapter 10

Carrying Vitality and Consciousness Carrying vitality and consciousness, embracing them as one, can you keep them from parting? Concentrating energy, making it supple, can you be like an infant? Purifying hidden perception, can you make it flawless? Loving the people, governing the nation,

Keep your body and spermatic soul closely united, and ensure that they do not become separated. Apply yourself such that the air you breathe in, converted into the aerial soul, animates this composite, and keeps it intact as in a new-born baby. Withhold yourself from considerations which are too profound, in order not to wear yourself out. As for love of the people and anxiety for the state, limit yourself to non

Can you see as a child sees And keep the simple vision? See the inner oneness With absolute precision Hold all things in your embrace The entire world is in your care L

Can you keep the spirit and embrace the One without departing from them? Can you concentrate your vital force and achieve the highest degree of weakness like an infant? Can you clean and purify your profound insight so it will be spotless? Can you love the people and govern the state without knowledge (cunning)? Can you play the role of th

can you be uncontrived? As the gate of heaven opens and closes, can you be impassive? As understanding reaches everywhere, can you be innocent? Producing and developing, producing without possessing, doing without presuming, growing without domineering: this is called mysterious power. up

-action. Let the gates of heaven open and close, without wishing to do something, without interfering. Know all, be informed on everything, and for all that remain indifferent, as if you knew nothing. Produce, breed, without taking any credit for what has been produced, without exacting a return for your actions, without imposing yourself on those you govern. There you have the formula for transcendent action. up

et things be just as they are Extend acceptance everywhere Let go all need to comprehend The truth is here where all behold Their infinite capacity To welcome and enfold

e female in the opening and closing of the gates of Heaven? Can you understand all and penetrate all without taking any action? To produce things and to rear them, To produce, but not to take possession of them, To act, but not to rely on one's own ability, To lead them, but not to master them - This is called profound and secret virtue. up

Chapter 11

Thirty Spokes
Thirty spokes
join at the hub:
their use for the
cart is where
they are not.
When the
potter's wheel
makes a pot, the
use of the pot is
precisely where
there is n

A wheel is made
of thirty
perceptible
spokes, but it
turns due to the
imperceptible
central axis of
the hub. Vessels
are made of
perceptible clay,
but it is their
imperceptibl

The empty hub
at center Allows
a wheel to roll
The vacancy
within defines
The function of a
bowl The
openness

We put thirty
spokes together
and call it a wheel;
but it's on the
space where
there's nothing
that the usefulness
of the wheel
depends. We turn
clay to make a
vessel; but it's on
the space where
there's nothing
that the usefulness
of the vessel
depends. We
pierce and cut out
doors and
windows to make
a house;

Thirty spokes are
united around
the hub to make
a wheel, But it is
on its non-being
that the utility of
the carriage
depends. Clay is
moulded to form
a utensil, But it is
on its non-being
that the utility o

othing. When
you open doors
and windows for
a room, it is
where there is
nothing that they
are useful to the
room. Therefore
being is for
benefit,
Nonbeing is for
usefulness. up

e hollow that is
useful. The
imperceptible
holes which
make the doors
and windows of a
house, are its
essentials. It is
the imperceptible
that produces
effects and
results. up

within a house
Provides location
to reside The
open space that
is my heart Is
where ten
thousand things
abide

and it's on these
spaces where
there's nothing
that the usefulness
of the house
depends. Take
advantage of what
is, turn existing
into a great
advantage: just
make as much as
you can out of it
here. Feel free to
recognise the
possible
usefulness of
whats not yet here.
Prosper by clever
use of something
not yet.

f the utensil
depends. Doors
and windows are
cut out to make a
room, But it is on
its non-being that
the utility of the
room depends.
Therefore turn
being into
advantage, and
turn non-being
into utility. up

Chapter 12

Colors Colors blind people's eyes, Sounds deafen their ears; flavors spoil people's palates, the chase and the hunt craze people's minds; goods

Colours blind the eyes of man. Sound makes him deaf. Flavours exhaust his taste. Hunting and racing, by unchaining savage passions in him, madden his heart. The love of rare and difficult-to-obtain objects pu

Too much sound can make you deaf Too many colors leave you blind Can you let desire die down And not leave emptiness behi

The five colours tend to confuse the eye, the five sounds of music can deafen the ear, the five tastes all dull or spoil the palate. Excess of hunting and chasing makes a mind go mad. Things hard to get, keeps one on one's guard. Valuable things and products quite hard to get, can impede their owner's progress.

The five colours cause one's eyes to be blind. The five tones cause one's ears to be deaf. The five flavours cause one's palate to be spoiled. Racing and hunting cause one's mind to b

hard to obtain make people's actions harmful. Therefore sages work for the middle and not the eyes, leaving the latter and taking the former. up

shes him to efforts that harm him. Therefore the Sage looks to his stomach, and not his senses. renounces this, in order to embrace that. (He renounces what causes wear, in order to embrace what conserves). up

nd? Wanting things can drive you mad And acquisition makes you poor See that you are everything And leave off wanting more

So the wise man is concerned with his tummy before his eyes. He can consider the tummy first, not the eye. That is: He disregards the world outside - "that", and he accepts, goes for and in the end grabs the supernatural powers dormant within - his daoist "this". Therefore he rejects the one but accepts the other.

e mad. Goods that are hard to get injure one's activities. For this reason the sage is concerned with the belly and not the eyes, Therefore he rejects the one but accepts the other. up

Chapter 13

Favor and Disgrace Favor and disgrace seem alarming; high status greatly afflicts your person. What are favor and disgrace? Favor is the lower: get it and you're surprised, lose it and you're startled. This means favor and disgrace are alarming. Why does high status greatly afflict your person? The reason we hav

Favour, because it can be lost, is a source of worry. Greatness, because it can be ruined, is a source of fear. What do these two sentences mean? The first means that the care required to keep in favour, and the fear of losing it, fill the mind with worry. The second points out that ruin generally comes from caring t

Fame and shame are equal And so are gain and loss It isn't very difficult To get this point across Having fame you know that you Are terrified to lose it Making gain you always fear That others will abuse it Can you se

Be apprehensive when receiving favour or disgrace. Regard great trouble as seriously as you regard your body. What is meant by being apprehensive when receiving favour or disgrace? Favour is considered inferior. Be apprehensive when you receive them and also be apprehensive when you lose them. This is what is meant by being apprehensive when receiving favour or dis

e a lot of trouble is that we have selves. If we had no selves, what troubles would we have? Therefore those who embody nobility to act for the sake of the world seem to be able to draw the world to them, while those who embody love to act for the sake of the world seem to be worthy of the trust of the world. up

oo much for one's own greatness. He who has no personal ambition does not have to fear ruin. He who is only concerned about the greatness of the empire (and not that of himself), he who only desires the good of the empire (and not his own good), to him the empire should be confided (and it would be in good hands). up

e that you're not like Your image or reflection? Just see you are totality By looking in your own direction The one who is not limited Accepts whatever comes or goes And cares for everything around On opening and close

grace. What does it mean to regard great trouble as seriously as you regard your body? The reason why I have great trouble is that I have a body (and am attached to it). If I have no body, What trouble could I have? Therefore he who values the world as his body may be entrusted with the empire. He who loves the world as his body may be entrusted with the empire. up

Chapter 14

When You Look at It You Don't See It What you don't see when you look is called the unobtrusive. What you don't hear when you listen is called the rarefied. What you don't get when you grasp is called the subtle. These three cannot be completely fathomed, so they merge into one; above is not bright, below is not dark. Continuous, unnameable, it

Looking, one does not see it, for it is invisible. Listening, one does not hear it, for it is silent. Touching, one does not feel it, for it is impalpable. These three attributes must not be separated, for they designate one and the same being. This being, the Principle, is not light above and dark below, as are opaque material bodies. Like a slender thread, it unwinds itself (as continuous

When you look, it isn't there Listen and you cannot hear it It seems to be beyond your reach Because you are so near it This single source of everything Appears to be an empty image Though it cannot be understood You can see its n

Look at it, it can't be seen, is called the invisible. Listen to it, it can't be heard, is called the inaudible. Grasp at it, it can't be touched, is called the fine formless.. These three elude all solid inquiries And merge and become one. Its rising brings no light; its sinking, no darkness. Unceasing, continuous, it can't be defined, on the way back to where the

We look at it and do not see it; Its name is The Invisible. We listen to it and do not hear it; Its name is The Inaudible. We touch it and do not find it; Its name is The Subtle (formless). These three cannot be further inquired into, And hence merge into one. Going up high, it is not bright, and coming down low, it is not dark. Infinite and boundless, it cannot be given

returns again to nothing. This is called the stateless state, the image of no thing; this is called mental abstraction. When you face it you do not see its head, when you follow it you do not see its back. Hold the ancient Way so as to direct present existence: only when you can know the ancient can this be called the basic cycle of the Way. up

existence and action). It has no name of its own. It goes back as far as the time when there were no other beings but itself. It has no parts; from in front one sees no head, from behind no rear. It is this primordial Principle that has ruled, and rules, all beings right up to the present. Everything that has been, or is, since the ancient origin, is from the unwinding of the Principle. up

aked visage Follow it to nothingness Approach it where you have no face From nowhere to infinity This vacant image leaves no trace From never to eternity This naked face is what you are An empty, vacant, open door Forevermore ajar

re's nothing. It's called shape free from shapes; forms without form; the image of nothingness. That's why it's called the elusive; Go towards them, and you can see no physical front; go after them, and you see no rear. Hold on to the dao of old to master the things of the present. Master what once was, at the start, It's the essence of rarefied, pearl-stringed dao.

any name; It reverts to nothingness. This is called shape without shape, Form without objects. It is the Vague and Elusive. Meet it and you will not see its head. Follow it and you will not see its back. Hold on to the Tao of old in order to master the things of the present. From this one may know the primeval beginning (of the universe). This is called the bond of Tao. up

Chapter 15

Skilled Warriors of
Old Skilled
warriors of old
were subtle,
mysteriously
powerful, so deep
they were
unknowable. just
because they are
unknowable, I will
try to describe
them. Their
wariness was as
that of one
crossing a river in
winter, their
caution was as
that of one in fear
of all around; their
gravity was as that
of a guest, their
relaxation was as
that of ice at th

Those of old who
knew the way To
origin and source
within Have seen
the place where
wholeness And
infinity begin
Alert as one on a
frozen stream Or
one who watches
for the foe
Deferential as a
guest And
generous as
melting

Of old those who
were the best
rulers were subtly
mysterious and
profoundly
penetrating; Too
deep to
comprehend. And
because they
cannot be
comprehended, I
can only describe
them arbitrarily:
Cautious, like
crossing a frozen
stream in the
winter, Being at a
loss, like one
fearing danger on
all sides,
Reserved, like one
visiting, Supple
and pliant, like ice
about to melt.
Genuine, like a p

e melting point.
Simple as
uncarved wood,
open as the
valleys, they were
inscrutable as
murky water. Who
can, in turbidity,
use the gradual
clarification of
stillness? Who
can, long at rest,
use the gradual
enlivening of
movement? Those
who preserve this
Way do not want
fullness. Just
because of not
wanting fullness, it
is possible to use
to the full and not
make anew. up

snow Plain as an
uncarved block
of wood
Expansive as a
vale Transparent
just like water
Whose clarity will
never fail Can
you keep
yourself so still
That muddy
water clears?
And wait until
right action
Spontaneously
appears?

iece of uncarved
wood, Open and
broad, like a
valley, Merged and
undifferentiated,
like muddy water.
Who can make
muddy water
gradually clear
through
tranquillity? Who
can make the still
gradually come to
life through
activity? He who
embraces this Tao
does not want to
fill himself to
overflowing. It is
precisely because
there is no
overflowing that he
is beyond wearing
out and renewal.
up

Chapter 16

Attain the Climax
of Emptiness
Attain the climax of
emptiness,
preserve the
utmost quiet: as
myriad things act
in concert, I
thereby observe
the return. Things
flourish, then each
returns to its root.
Returning to the
root is called
stillness: stillness
is called return to
Life, return to Life
is called the
constant; knowin

See that you are
emptiness
Always quiet and
at peace You're
in the place
where all begins
The space where
all things cease
All things arise
and have their
day And then go
back

Attain complete
vacuity. Maintain
steadfast quietude.
All things come
into being, And I
see thereby their
return. All things
flourish, But each
one returns to its
root. This return to
its root means
tranquillity. It is
called returning to
its destiny. To
return to destiny is
called the eternal
(Tao). To know the
eternal is called
enlightenment. Not
to know

g the constant is
called
enlightenment.
Acts at random, in
ignorance of the
constant, bode ill.
Knowing the
constant gives
perspective; this
perspective is
impartial.
Impartiality is the
highest nobility;
the highest nobility
is divine, and the
divine is the Way.
This Way is
everlasting, not
endangered by
physical death. up

f the two states of
life and death), is
wisdom. To ignore
it, is foolish. Those
ignorant of this law
cause misfortune
(through their
untimely
interference in
things). He who
knows that this law
weighs heavily on
beings, is just
(treats all beings
according to their
nature, with
equity), like a King,
like Heaven, like
the Principle. In
consequence he
lasts until the end
of his days, not
having made
himself any
enemies. up

to the single
source Returning
to serenity With
no regret and no
remorse When
you see the
source within
You only give
assent You see
you're
everlasting And
eternally
omnificent

the eternal is to act
blindly to result in
disaster. He who
knows the eternal
is all-embracing.
Being
all-embracing, he
is impartial. Being
impartial, he is
kingly (universal).
Being kingly, he is
one with Nature.
Being one with
Nature, he is in
accord with Tao.
Being in accord
with Tao, he is
everlasting And is
free from danger
throughout his
lifetime. up

Chapter 17

Very Great Leaders Very great leaders in their domains are only known to exist. Those next best are beloved and praised. The lesser are feared and despised. Therefore when faith is i

In the early days (when, in human affairs, everything still conformed to the action of the Principle), subjects scarcely knew that they had a prince (so discreet was the action of the latter). After this the people loved and flattered their prince (because of his good deeds), but later on, they feared him (because of his laws), and scorned him (because of

It's best if you are barely known The lesser state is being praised Worse is being hated Just stay empty and am

Of the best the people hardly ever know they exist; The next best they flock to and praise for nothing. The next they shrink from; the next get reviled. "Not believing people you turn them into liars" - such bosses don't command the people's faith. They

The best (rulers) are those whose existence is (merely) known by the people. The next best are those who are loved and praised. The next are those who are feared. And the next are those who are despised. It is only when one does no

nsufficient and there is disbelief, it is from the high value placed on words. Works are accomplished, tasks are completed, and ordinary folk all say they are acting spontaneously. up

his unjust acts). They became disloyal, though having been treated disloyally. They lost confidence in him though receiving only good words which were never put into effect. How delicate was the touch of ancient rulers. When everything prospered under their administration, the people believed they had done everything themselves, of their own free will. up

azed Only do what must be done And see you are the one alone When you finish all will say We did this on our own

lose faith in them and take to oaths! The wise man is a clever ruler; he values his words highly. It's so hard to get a single word from at any price that when his task is finished, a work well done, everyone says, "It happened by itself, and we did it."

t have enough faith in others that others will have no faith in him. (The great rulers) value their words highly. They accomplish their task; they complete their work. Nevertheless their people say that they simply follow Nature. up

Chapter 18

When the Great Way Is Deserted
When the Great Way is deserted, then there is humanitarian duty. When intelligence comes forth, there is great fabrica

When action conforming to the Principle dwindles, (when men cease to act with spontaneous goodness and fairness), artificial principles of goodness and fairness, prudence and wisdom (are invented). These artificial principles soon degenerate into poli

Goodness and compliance
Came when people lost the

When the great dao declined, jen and i arose, humanity and righteousness." Next, when brightness and know-how came in vogue, the great pretence fully started. When the six family rela

When the great Tao declined, The doctrine of humanity and righteousness arose. When knowledge and wisdom appeared, There emerged great hypocrisy. When the six family relation

tion. When relations are discordant, then there is family love. When the national polity is benighted and confused, then there are loyal ministers. up

tics. When parents no longer live in natural harmony, they try to make up for this deficit by inventing artificial principles of filial piety and paternal affection. When states had fallen into disarray, they invented the loyal minister stereotype. up

way Spontaneity declined
Hypocrisy was here to stay

tionships are not in harmony
There's open talk of kind parents" dutiful sons" and deep love to children. A confused country enmeshed in disorder praises ministers in chaos and misrule.

ships are not in harmony, There will be the advocacy of filial piety and deep love to children. When a country is in disorder, There will be the praise of loyal ministers. up

Chapter 19

Eliminate
Sagacity,
Abandon
Knowledge
Eliminate
sagacity,
abandon
knowledge, and
the people
benefit a
hundredfold.
Eliminate
humanitarianism,
abandon duty,
and the people
return to familial
love. Eliminate
craft, ab

Reject (artificial,
conventional,
political) wisdom
and prudence, (in
order to return to
primal natural
uprightness). and
the people will be
a hundred times
happier. Reject
(artificial,
conventional)
goodness and
fairness, (filial and
fraternal piety),
and the people will
come back (for
their well-being, to
natural goodness
and fairness),

Banish learned
discourse And
everyone will be
content Eliminate
propriety
Increase
astonishment
Stay away from
fraud and
swindle
Everyone is
bound to gain
You reall

Banish wisdom,
discard
knowledge, Then
the people will
benefit a hundred
times. Banish
human love, just
dump righteous,
moral justice, and
then the people
will be dutiful and
recover deep love
of their kin. Banish
cunning and skill,
dispel profit;
dismiss utility,"
then thieves and
robbers will
disappear. These
three things are
not enough; e

Abandon
sageliness and
discard wisdom;
Then the people
will benefit a
hundredfold.
Abandon
humanity and
discard
righteousness;
Then the people
will return to filial
piety and deep
love. Abandon
skill and discard
profit; Then

andon profit, and
theft will no
longer exist.
These three
become
insufficient when
used for
embellishment
causing there to
be attachments.
See the basic,
embrace the
unspoiled lessen
selfishness,
diminish desire.
up

to spontaneous
filial and paternal
piety. Reject art
and gain, and
evildoers will
disappear. (With
the primordial
simplicity, they will
return to primordial
honesty).
Renounce these
three artificial
categories, for the
artificial is
good-for-nothing.
Be attached to
simplicity and
naturalness. Have
few personal
interests, and few
desires. up

y have it all you
know There is no
basis to complain
Can you see
your empty core?
It isn't missing,
gone or hidden
Just let go of
neediness And it
will come
unbidden

xternals are
somehow
decorations,
purpose's not
enough; they tend
to rob life and
make it too little
complicated.
Therefore let
people hold well
on to keeping
accessories;
keeping simplicity
to look at. Go on
and shield their
internal soul's
nature as some
ritual, raw block to
hold, their private,
secret means and
foster less ardent
desires.

there will be no
thieves or
robbers.
However, these
three things are
ornaments (wen)
and are not
adequate.
Therefore let
people hold on to
these: Manifest
plainness,
Embrace
simplicity,
Reduce
selfishness,
Have few
desires. up

Chapter 20

You need not give
a yes or no Such
distinctions matter
little Keep your
vision open And
be at center
noncommittal See
that it's ridiculous
To seek success
and fear to fail To
ever want what
others want To
think you always
must prevail Other
people look so
bright I am dark
and void

and null Others
are so very sharp
While I alone am
dull Others are so
purposeful Only I
don't understand
Aimless, drifting,
weak and dumb
Uninteresting and
bland I see I'm
different from the
rest For I take in
what's plainly
shown And I take
my sustenance
Only from the
great unknown

Chapter 21

The Countenance of Great Virtue For the countenance of great virtue, only the Way is to be followed. As a thing, the Way is abstract and elusive: elusive and abstract, there are images in it; abstract and elusive, there is something t

All of the beings which play a role, in the great manifestation of the cosmic theater, have come from the Principle, through its virtue (its unwinding). The Principle is indistinct and indeterminate, mysterious and obscure. In its indistinction and indetermination there are types, a multitude of beings. In its mystery and o

Seeming utter emptiness Quite impossible to trace Yet it contains all images Within its wide embrace Appearing total darkness Yet you see that it is ri

The marks of great virtue follow alone from the (one) dao. What's called one dao seems impalpable and vague, not to be measured at all. Dao is an elusive, virtually incommensurable form, but eluding, elusive it contains sub-forms. Within it lie idea-images of coming things, within it are some shadowy entities or some dormant, vibrant life force of the firstborn, dim essence - even of objects, somehow, but much raref

The all-embracing quality of the great virtue follows alone from the Tao. The thing that is called Tao is eluding and vague. Vague and eluding, there is in it the form. Eluding and vague, in it are things. Deep and obscure, in it is the essence.

here. Recondite, hidden, it has vitality therein: that vitality is very real; it has truth therein. From ancient times to now, its name is the undeparting; thereby are seen all beauties. How do I know all beauties are thus? By this. up

bscurity there is an essence which is reality. From ancient times until the present, its name (its being) has stayed the same, all beings have come from it. How do I know that it was the origin of all beings? ... (By objective observation of the universe, which reveals that contingencies must have come from the absolute). up

ght To stay with its obscurity The only origin of light This ever present openness At center and within Can be seen just anytime So look and look again

ied - latent in the essence is the life-force. The life-force is real and to be trusted. It's true, and can be set to operate. and latent in it are evidences. From the days of old till now its chunks havent departed or ceased, By its chunks we can view some origin of all descended units. How do I know a father of a thing? How to know how some origin of a manifestation is formed? By much developed intuition, possibly.

The essence is very real; in it are evidences. From the time of old until now, its name (manifestations) ever remains. By which we may see the beginning of all things. How do I know that the beginning of all things are so? Through this (Tao). up

Chapter 22

Be Tactful and You Remain Whole Be tactful and you remain whole; bend and you remain straight. The hollow is filled, the old is renewed. Economy is gain, excess is confusion. Therefore sages embrace unity as a model for the world. Not seeing themselves, they are therefore clear. Not asserting themselves, they are therefore ou

In the old days they said, the incomplete shall be made whole, the bent shall be straightened, the empty shall be filled, the worn shall be renewed. Simplicity makes for success, multiplicity leads one astray. Therefore the Sage who holds himself to unity, is the model for the empire, (for the world, the ideal man). He shines, because he does not show off. He imposes himself bec

Overcome by giving up See that you are really nil Look into your emptiness If you want to have your fill Be satisfied with little Just content with what you need If you are always wanting more You surely are consumed by greed Abide in your simplicity Though you are not

"To remain whole, yield somewhat or seem curved and bent if you may." To become straight, let yourself look bent. To become full, seem hollow. Seem tattered now, that you can be renewed. Those that have little, can get more, To have plenty is to be confused.. Therefore the wise man clasps the primal unity, testing by it everything under heaven by himself - it. He doesn't show himself much, he is there

To yield is to be preserved whole. To be bent is to become straight. To be empty is to be full. To be worn out is to be renewed. To have little is to possess. To have plenty is to be perplexed. Therefore the sage embraces the One And becomes the model of the world. He does not justify himself; therefore he becomes prominent. He does

tstanding. Not congratulating themselves, they are therefore meritorious. Not taking pride in themselves, they last long. It is just because they do not contend that no one in the world can contend with them. Is it empty talk, the old saying that tact keeps you whole? When truthfulness is complete, it still resorts to this. up

ause he does not claim to be right. One finds merit in him, because he does not brag. He increases constantly because he does not push himself. As he does not oppose himself to anyone, no one is opposed to him. The axioms from the old days cited above, are they not full of sense? Yes, towards him who is perfect, (who does nothing to attract to himself), all run spontaneously. up

on display See all things are shining bright In marvelous array If you do not boast or brag Everyone will hold you high If you do not argue You will prevail thereby Only see you are complete And all things have come to you Overcome by giving up All except your inner view

fore luminous and clear. He doesn't define himself, therefore he is distinct. He doesn't boast, therefore people give him credit: he succeeds by that. He's never outright proud of his work, and therefore it endures. Because he doesn't contend, none in the world can contend with him. So the old saying To remain whole, seem twisted!" was no idle word; for true wholeness can only be won by return to dao.

not boast of himself; therefore he is given credit. He does not brag; therefore he can endure for long. It is precisely because he does not compete that the world cannot compete with him. Is the ancient saying, "To yield is to be preserved whole," empty words? Truly he will be preserved and (prominence and credit) will come to him. up

Chapter 23

To Speak Rarely
Is Natural To
speak rarely is
natural. That is
why a gusty wind
doesn't last the
morning, a
downpour of rain
doesn't last the
day. Who does
this? Heaven and
earth. If even
heaven and earth
cannot go on
forever, how much
less can human
beings! Therefore
those who follow
the Way assimilate
t

Say your piece
and then be still
Like nature in a
storm That rains
and blows and
ceases And sees
the sun reborn
Open to the
inward view You
are at one with
all existence
There's nothi

Nature says few
words. For the
same reason a
whirlwind does not
last a whole
morning. Nor does
a rainstorm last a
whole day. What
causes them? It is
Heaven and Earth
(Nature). If even
Heaven and Earth
cannot make them
last long, How
much less can
man? Therefore
he who follows
Tao is identified
with Tao. He who
follows virtue is
identified with
virtue. He who
abandons (Tao) is
identified with the
aba

o the Way; the
virtuous assimilate
to virtue, those
who have lost
assimilate to loss.
Those who
assimilate to the
Way are happy to
gain it, those who
assimilate to virtue
too are happy to
gain it, and those
who assimilate to
loss are also
happy to gain it.
When trust is
insufficient, there
is distrust. up

ng blocking up
the way Or
putting up
resistance If
you're at home
with nothingness
And simply trust
what comes
about You'll find
that all is in its
place Without a
question or a
doubt

ndonment (of
Tao). He who is
identified with Tao
- Tao is also happy
to have him. He
who is identified
with virtue - virtue
is also happy to
have him. And he
who is identified
with the
abandonment (of
Tao) - the
abandonment (of
Tao) is also happy
to abandon him.
Those who lack
trust will not be
trusted. It is only
when one does not
have enough faith
in others that
others will have no
faith in him. up

Chapter 24

Those on Tiptoe
Don't Stand Up
Those on tiptoe
don't stand up,
those who take
long strides don't
walk; those who
see themselves
are not
perceptive, those
who assert
themselves are
not illustrious;
those who

By dint of holding
oneself on tiptoe,
one loses one's
balance. By trying
to take too great a
stride, one does
not go forward. By
making a show of
oneself, one loses
one's reputation.
Through imposing
oneself, one loses
one's influence.
Through boasting
about oneself, one
becomes
discredited.
Through

Who stands on
tiptoe topples
Who runs ahead
soon loses
speed Who goes
on show is
hidden Who
pushes far gives
up the lead

Who stands on
tiptoe, doesn't
stand steady; He
who takes the
longest strides,
doesn't walk.." He
who does his own
looking sees little,
and he who shows
or reveals himself
is hardly luminous
He who justifies
and defines
himself isn't
subsequently
distinct. He who
boasts of what he
will do succeeds in
nothing; Who
brags doesn't
endure for long.
Who is proud of
his work, achieves
n

He who stands
on tiptoe is not
steady. He who
strides forward
does not go. He
who shows
himself is not
luminous. He
who justifies
himself is not
prominent. He
who boasts of
himself is not
given credit. He

glorify
themselves have
no merit, those
who are proud of
themselves do
not last. On the
Way, these are
called
overconsumption
and excess
activity. Some
people disdain
them, so those
with the Way
abstain. up

pushing oneself,
one ceases to be
augmented. In the
light of the
Principle all these
ways of acting are
odious, distasteful.
They are
superfluous
excesses. They
are like a pain in
the stomach, a
tumour in the
body. He who has
principles (in
conformity with the
Principle), does
not act like this. up

d Don't depart
from what is
given The ever
present here and
now Don't
overreach and
don't oppose
Invite, admire
and allow

nothing well lasting.
Such people are
like remnants of
food and tumours
of action from the
dao point of view.
Good braggarts
could be dregs. So
it's said "Pass
round superfluous
dishes to those
that have already
had enough, Such
things of disgust
all are likely to
detest and reject in
disgust." So the
man of dao spurns
them. The man
that has dao
doesn't stay to
bray and show off.

who brags does
not endure for
long. From the
point of view of
Tao, these are
like remnants of
food and
tumours of
action, Which all
creatures detest.
Therefore those
who possess
Tao turn away
from them. up

Chapter 25

Something
Undifferentiated
Something
undifferentiated
was born before
heaven and earth;
still and silent,
standing alone and
unchanging, going
through cycles
unending, able to
be mother to the
world. I do not
know its name; I
label it the Way.
Imposing on it a
name, I call it
Great. Greatness
means it go

Before creation
did occur This
blessed
emptiness was
here Alone
forever and at
peace The
source of all that
does appear
Eternally
unchanging
Forever lacking
limit This void is
all potential The
everlasting
ultimat

There was
something
undifferentiated
and yet complete,
Which existed
before heaven and
earth. Soundless
and formless, it
depends on
nothing and does
not change. It
operates
everywhere and is
free from danger.
It may be
considered the
mother of the
universe. I do not
know its name; I
call it Tao. If forced
to give it a name, I
shall call it Great.
Now being

es; going means
reaching afar;
reaching afar
means return.
Therefore the Way
is great, heaven is
great, earth is
great, and kingship
is also great.
Among domains
are four greats, of
which kingship is
one. Humanity
emulates earth,
earth emulates
heaven, heaven
emulates the Way,
the Way emulates
Nature. up

e It flows through
all existence And
then returns to
source It's ever
at your center
Your only true
recourse For
here begins the
universe The
earth and
humankind
Following this
greatest way You
can never be
defined

great means
functioning
everywhere.
Functioning
everywhere means
far-reaching. Being
far-reaching
means returning to
the original point.
Therefore Tao is
great Heaven is
great. Earth is
great. And the king
is also great. Man
models himself
after Earth. Earth
models itself after
Heaven. Heaven
models itself after
Tao. And Tao
models itself after
Nature. up

Chapter 26

Gravity Is the Root of Lightness Gravity is the root of lightness; calm is the master of excitement. Thereby do exemplary people travel all day without leaving their equipment. Though they have a look of prosper

The heavy is the base (root) of the light. Stillness is the prince of movement. (These things should be always united in a just temperament). Therefore a wise prince, when he travels (in his light carriage), never separates himself from the heavy wagons which

The naked center doesn't change Its quietude is absolute Yet from it spring all things that move This bare awareness is the root Can you go about all day And never leave your t

The solid is the platform of the light, and the heavy is the root of the light. (Maybe firm integrity has to be the basis of light frivolity). Quiet strength rules over activity, the not-so-active could be the big boss of the hasty. So the wise man travels all day and never leaves his baggage; he who travels all day hardly likes to be separated from his provision-chart: However great and glorious the view, he sits quiet and dispassionate

The heavy is the root of the light. The tranquil is the ruler of the hasty. Therefore the sage travels all day Without leaving his baggage. Even at the sight of magnificent scenes He remains leisurely

ity, their resting place is transcendent. What can be done about heads of state who take the world lightly in their own selfinterest? Lack of gravity loses servants of state; instability loses heads of state. up

carry his baggage. However beautiful the landscape through which he passes, he takes care to lodge only in peaceful places. Alas, how could an emperor behave so foolishly, losing all authority by dint of frivolity, and all the rest through his waywardness? up

rue abode No matter how enticing are The splendors of the road? Don't think that you can run around And act a perfect fool Just see that you are at the eye Of nature's whirlpool

and indifferent. How is it that a lord with ten thousand chariots Should behave lightheartedly in his empire? If he is lighthearted, the minister will be destroyed. If he is hasty, the ruler is lost. up

Chapter 27

Good Works Good works are trackless, good words are flawless, good planning isn't calculating. What is well closed has no bolt locking it, but cannot be opened. What is well bound has no rope confining it, but cannot be untied. Therefore sages always consider it good to save people, so that there are no wasted humans; they al

A good walker leaves no trace, a good speaker offends no one, a good reckoner needs no tally, an expert locksmith can make one that no one can open, an expert on knots can make them so that no one can untie them. (all specialists have their speciality, which makes their fame, from which they take their profit). Likewise the Sage (Confucian politician), the professional savi

Can you walk and leave no tracks? Make no errors when you talk? Count without a tally? Secure a door without a lock? You can abandon no one There's nothing you can leave

A good traveller leaves no track or trace. A good speech leaves no flaws. A good reckoner uses no counters. A well-shut door needs no bolts, and yet it cannot be opened. A well-tied knot needs no rope and yet none can untie it. Therefore the sage is always good in saving men and consequently no man is rejected. He is always good in saving thing

ways consider it good to save beings, so that there are no wasted beings. So good people are teachers of people who are not good. People who are not good are students of people who are good. Those who do not honor teachers or care for students are greatly deluded, even if knowledgeable. This is called an essential subtlety. up

our of men and things, has his own procedures. He considers himself as the born master of other men, regarding them as material born for his craft. Now that is to blind oneself, (to shade out the light, the Daoist principles). Not wishing to rule, nor to appropriate, others; although wise, seeming like a madman (persisting to live in retreat); this is the essential truth. up

behind In you there are no limits You are forever unconfined What happens is spontaneous Good and bad are just the same In origin identical Beyond both praise and blame

s and consequently nothing is rejected. This is called following the light (of Nature). Therefore the good man is the teacher of the bad, And the bad is the material from which the good may learn. He who does not value the teacher, Or greatly care for the material, Is greatly deluded although he may be learned. Such is the essential mystery. up

Chapter 28

Know the Male
Know the Male
Know the male,
keep the female;
be humble toward
the world. Be
humble to the
world, and eternal
power never
leaves, returning
again to
innocence.
Knowing the white,
keep the black; be
an exemplar for
the world. Be an
exemplar for the
world, and eternal
power never goes
awry,

Know the strong
but keep the
weak The whole
wide world is
born in you You'll
see just what a
child sees A vast
and
comprehensive
view Know the
light but keep the
dark And watch
ten thousand
things emerge In
you they have
their residence
Where spa

He who knows the
male and keeps to
the female
Becomes the
ravine of the world.
Being the ravine of
the world, He will
never depart from
eternal virtue, But
returns to a state
of infancy. He who
knows the white
and yet keeps to
the black Becomes
the model for the
world. Being the
model for the
world, He will
never deviate from
eternal virtue, But
returns to the state

returning again to
infinity. Knowing
the glorious, keep
the ignominious;
be open to the
world. Be open to
the world, and
eternal power
suffices, returning
again to simplicity.
Simplicity is lost to
make instruments,
which sages
employ as
functionaries.
Therefore the
great fashioner
does no splitting.
up

ce and time
converge Know
the high but keep
the low Humility
will honor you
Attend to your
vacuity There's
nothing else to
do Be like an
uncarved block
of wood Don't
squander your
potential Or
overlook your
vacant core
Nothing else is
so essential

of the
non-ultimate. He
who knows glory
but keeps to
humility Becomes
the valley of the
world, He will be
proficient in eternal
virtue, And returns
to the state of
simplicity
(uncarved wood).
When the
uncarved wood is
broken up, it is
turned into
concrete things.
But when the sage
uses it, he
becomes the
leading official.
Therefore the
great ruler does
not cut up. up

Chapter 29

Should You
Want Should you
want to take the
world, and
contrive to do so,
I see you won't
manage to finish.
The most
sublime
instrument in the
world cannot be
contrived. Those
who contrive
spoil it; those
who ding lose it.
So c

He who holds the
empire would, in
my view, be
wishing for failure
should he want to
manipulate it (to
act positively, to
govern actively).
The empire is a
mechanism of
extreme delicacy.
It should be let go
all alone. It should
not be touched. He
who touches it,
deranges it. He
who wishes to
appropriate it,
loses it. When he
governs

Do you want to
change the
world? You
cannot possibly
succeed The
given cannot be
improved On this
the seers are
agreed At times
you find you're
out in front At
other times you
fall behind
Sometimes
you're all
commotion But
afterwards you m

When one
desires to take
over the empire
and act on it
(interfere with it),
I see that he will
not succeed. The
empire is a
spiritual thing,
and should not
be acted on. He
who acts on it
harms it. He who
holds on to it
loses it

reatures
sometimes go
and sometimes
follow,
sometimes puff
and sometimes
blow, are
sometimes
strong and
sometimes weak,
begin sometime
and end
sometime;
therefore sages
remove
extremes,
remove
extravagance,
remove
arrogance. up

, the Sage lets all
people (and their
sum, the empire)
go free according
to their several
natures, the agile
and the slow, the
ardent and the
apathetic, the
strong and the
weak, the
long-lived and the
short-lived. He
limits his action to
the suppression of
excesses which
would harm the
whole, such as
power, wealth, and
ambition. up

ust unwind When
all around is
turmoil Just stay
with the serene
You are the quiet
center Of the
ever changing
scene Can you
see things as
they are And let
them be all on
their own?
Remain in pure
awareness You
never need to
stray from home

. Among
creatures some
lead and some
follow. Some
blow hot and
some blow cold.
Some are strong
and some are
weak. Some may
break and some
may fall.
Therefore the
sage discards
the extremes, the
extravagant, and
the excessive. up

Chapter 30

Assisting Human
Leaders with the
Way Those who
assist human
leaders with the
Way do not coerce
the world with
weapons, for these
things are apt to
backfire. Brambles
grow where an
army has been;
there are always
bad years after a
war. Therefore the
good are effective,
that is all; they do
not p

There is an
ancient way to
lead That just
allows and does
not force For
what goes out
will come around
And violence will
lead to wars The
one who sees
completes a task
And stops wh

He who assists the
ruler with Tao
does not dominate
the world with
force. The use of
force usually bring
requit. Wherever
armies are
stationed, briars
and thorns grow.
Great wars are
always followed by
famines. A good
(general) achieves
his purpose and
stops, But dares
not seek to
dominate the
world. He achieves
his purpose but
does not brag
about it.

resume to grab
power thereby:
they are effective
but not conceited,
effective but not
proud, effective
but not arrogant.
They are effective
when they have to
be, effective but
not coercive. If you
peak in strength,
you then age; this,
it is said, is
unguided. The
unguided soon
come to an end.
up

en it is done
Seeing all is on
its own And not
controlled by
anyone The seer
sees that all is
well And does
not need to
please Just gives
acceptance
everywhere Puts
everyone at ease

He achieves his
purpose but does
not boast about it.
He achieves his
purpose but is not
proud of it. He
achieves his
purpose but only
as an unavoidable
step. He achieves
his purpose but
does not aim to
dominate. (For)
after things reach
their prime, they
begin to grow old,
Which means
being contrary to
Tao. Whatever is
contrary to Tao will
soon perish. up

Chapter 31

Fine Weapons

Fine weapons are implements of ill omen: people may despise them, so those with the Way do not dwell with them. Therefore the place of honor for the cultured is on the left, while the honored place for the martialist is on the right.

Weapons, being instruments of ill omen, are not the tools of the cultured, who use them only when unavoidable. They consider it best to be aloof; they win without beautifying it. Those who bea

Weapons lead to violence Which everyone despises Avoid them altogether Allow no compromises If use of weapons has to be When enemies just leave no choice Use them but reluctantly In victory do not rejoice Ascendancy brings so

row And triumph doesn't carry pleasure It severs you from wholeness And robs you of your real treasure Victory is like a funeral Where loss of life must make you sad For putting other people down Never ought to make you glad

Chapter 32

The Way Is
Eternally
Nameless The
Way is eternally
simplicity is small,
the world cannot
subordinate it. If
lords and
monarchs can
keep to it, all
beings will
naturally resort to
them. Heaven and
earth combine,
thus showering
sweet dew

The Principle has
no name of its
own. It is nature.
This nature so
unmanifest is
stronger than
anything. If princes
and emperors
were to conform
themselves to it,
all beings would
collaborate with
them
spontaneously;
heaven and earth
would act in
perfect harmony,
sprinkli

Awareness is not
limited It's like an
uncarved block
of wood With
infinite potential
Beyond all
usefulness for
good If leaders
could stay
centered In
awareness pure
and pl

Tao is eternal and
has no name.
Though its
simplicity seems
insignificant, none
in the world can
master it. If kings
and barons would
hold on to it, all
things would
submit to the
spontaneously.
Heaven and earth
unite to drip sweet
dew. Without the
command of men,
its drips evenly
over al

. No humans
command it; it is
even by nature.
Start fashioning,
and there are
names; once
names also exist,
you should know
when to stop. By
knowing when to
stop, you are not
endangered. The
Way is to the world
as rivers and
oceans to valley
streams. up

ng a sweet dew
(the best possible
omen); the people
would be
governable without
the need for
constraint. The
Principle is, with
reference to the
diversity of beings
in the world, like
the mass of great
rivers and oceans
with reference to
trickles and
rivulets of water.
up

ain This world
would be as
nourishing As
nature's gentle
rain Everyone
would be at
peace And
always living in
the whole
Opposition and
division Could
never take their
toll

I. As soon as there
were regulations
and institutions,
there were names.
As soon as there
were names, know
that it is time to
stop. It is by
knowing when to
stop that one can
be free from
danger.
Analogically, Tao
in the world may
be compared to
rivers and streams
running into the
sea. up

Chapter 33

Those Who
Know Others
Those who know
others are wise;
those who know
themselves are
enlightened.
Those who
overcome others
are powerful;
those who
overcome
themselves

Knowing others is
wisdom, but
knowing oneself is
superior wisdom,
(one's own nature
being most hidden
and profound).
Imposing one's will
on others is
strength; but
imposing it on
oneself is superior
strength (one's
own passions
being the most
difficult to subdue).
Being satisfied
(content with what
destiny has given),
is tru

It may be said
that you are wise
To see yourself
as others do But
you are wiser still
to see From your
own central point
of

He who knows
others is wise;
He who knows
himself is
enlightened. He
who conquers
others has
physical
strength. He who
conquers himself
is strong. He who
is conte

are strong.
Those who are
contented are
rich; those who
act strongly have
will. Those who
do not lose their
place endure;
those who die
without perishing
live long. up

e wealth; being
master of oneself
(bending oneself
to the dispositions
of destiny) is true
character. Staying
in one's (natural)
place (that which
destiny has given),
makes for a long
lifer. After death,
not ceasing to be,
is true longevity,
(which is the lot of
those who have
lived in conformity
with nature and
destiny). up

view Then you
see you have it
all The riches
that are always
here Belong to
you completely
Because your
vision is so clear

nted is rich. He
who acts with
vigour has will.
He who does not
lose his place
(with Tao) will
endure. He who
dies but does not
really perish
enjoys long life.
up

Chapter 34

The Great Way is Universal; The Great Way is universal it can apply to the left or the right. All beings depend on it for life, and it does not refuse. Its accomplishments fulfilled, it does not dwell on them. It lovingly nurtures all beings, b

The great Principle extends itself in all directions. It lends itself willingly to the genesis of all beings (its participants). When a work is accomplished, it does not attribute it to itself. It nourishes all beings with kindness, without imposing itself on them as a master (for having nourished them; leaving them free; not exacting any degrading return from them).
Beaus

The empty center's everywhere It flows both left and right It brings to pass ten thousand things And yet it never leaves your sight It welcomes everything around On nothing does it make a

The Great Tao flows everywhere. It may go left or right. All things depend on it for life, and it does not turn away from them. It accomplishes its task, but does not claim credit for it. It clothes and feeds all things but does not claim to be

ut does not act as their ruler. As it has no desire, it can be called small. As all beings take to it, yet it does not act as their ruler, it can be called great. Therefore sages never contrive greatness; that is why they can become so great. up

e of its constant disinterestedness, one might think it would become diminished. This is not so. All beings to who it is so liberal, run towards it. It therefore finds itself magnified (through this universal trust). The Sage imitates this conduct. He, also, makes himself small (through his disinterestedness and his delicate reserve), and acquires thereby true greatness. up

claim It's in the heart of each and all This ultimate without a name Some can see that it is great And some will say that it's obscure It is your real identity Simplicity that will endure

master over them. Always without desires it may be called the Small. All things come to it and it does not master them; it may be called the Great. Therefore (the sage) never strives himself for the great, and thereby the great is achieved. up

Chapter 35

Holding the
Great Image
When holding
the Great Image,
the world goes
on and on
without harm,
peaceful, even,
tranquil. Where
there is music
and dining,
passing travelers
stop; b

Because he
resembles the
great prototype
(the Principle,
through his
disinterested
devotion), all come
to the Sage. He
welcomes them
all, does them
good, and gives
them rest, peace,
and happiness.
Music and good
cheer may hold up
a passer-by for but
a night, (since
sensual pleasur

Totality will be
with you If you
can see the
simple presence
Although there's
danger all
around You give
complete
acceptance
Good music,
food and
company Are
welcome when
you're

Hold fast to the
great form (Tao),
And all the world
will come. They
come and will
encounter no
harm; But enjoy
comfort, peace,
and health.
When there are
music and
dainties, Passing

ut the issue of
the Way is so
plain as to be
flavorless. When
you look at it, it is
invisible; when
you listen to it, it
is inaudible;
when you use it,
it cannot be
exhausted. up

es are fleeting and
leave nothing
behind). Whereas
the exposition of
the great principle
of disinterested
devotion, simple
and gentle, which
charms neither the
eyes nor the ears,
pleases, engraves
itself, and is of an
inexhaustible
fecundity in
matters of practical
application. up

traveling The
inner truth seems
tasteless Yet it
produces
everything You
look and you see
nothing You
listen and hear
silence Its use is
inexhaustible It's
ever worthy of
reliance

strangers will
stay. But the
words uttered by
Tao, How insipid
and tasteless!
We look at it; it is
imperceptible.
We listen to it; it
is inaudible. We
use it; it is
inexhaustible. up

Chapter 36

Should You Want to Contain Should you want to contain something, you must deliberately let it expand. Should you want to weaken something, you must deliberately let it grow strong. Should you want to eliminate something, you must deliberately allow it to flourish. Sho

The beginning of contraction necessarily follows the maximum of expansion. Weakness follows strength, decadence follows prosperity, depravation follows opulence. This is a subtle insight (that many do not wish to see). All preceding strength and superiority is expiated by subsequent debility and inferiority

You cannot be diminished Unless you've been inflated You cannot be defeated Unless you've been elated You cannot be belittled Unless you've been esteemed Unless you'

What's in the end to be shrunk can first be stretched. The one who is to be made to dwindle (in power) can first be caused to expand; and then it's necessary first to expand. Whatever is to be weakened must begin by being made strong [enough for it first of all]. He who is to be laid low can first be exalted to power. So: first promote, next destroy. Or: To destroy, first promote. What's to be overthrown must b

In order to contract, It is necessary first to expand. In order to weaken, It is necessary first to strengthen. In order to destroy, It is necessary first to promote. In order to grasp, It is necessary first

uld you want to take something away, you must deliberately grant it. This is called subtle illumination. Flexibility and yielding overcome adamant coerciveness. Fish shouldn't be taken from the depths; the effective tools of the nation shouldn't be shown to others. up

. More calls for less, excess calls for deficit. A fish should not leave the depths (where it lives ignored but in security, in order to show itself at the surface where it could be harpooned). A state should not show its resources (if it does not wish the others to turn against it in order to crush it). up

re wholly missing You cannot be redeemed The soft and slow can overcome The rigid and the hard and fast Just see your inner emptiness For nothing else is made to last

egin by being set up. He who would be a taker must begin as a giver. And this is the fine art. of dimming" one's light. According to this [set-up] the soft overcomes the hard; and the weak, the strong. [Such things can happens, but most often not, or what?] Fish should be left in the deep pool, not taken away from water. And sharp weapons of the state should not be displayed, but left where nobody can see them.

to give. This is called subtle light. The weak and the tender overcome the hard and the strong. Fish should not be taken away from water. And sharp weapons of state should not be displayed to the people. up

Chapter 37

The Way Is
Always
Uncontrived The
Way is always
uncontrived, yet
there's nothing it
doesn't do. If
lords and
monarchs could
keep to it, all
beings would
evolve
spontaneously.
When they have

The Principle is
always non-acting
(not acting
actively), and yet it
does everything
(without seeming
to participate). If
the prince and the
lords could govern
like that (without
poking their fingers
in it), all beings
would become
spontaneously
perfect (by
returning to
nature). It would
only rem

Only see you're
doing nothing
Yet not a thing is
left undone For
all things happen
on their own In
you who are the
all in one If
leaders could be
centered All ten
thousand thing

Tao invariably
takes no action,
and yet there is
nothing left
undone. If kings
and barons can
keep it, all things
will transform
spontaneously.
If, after
transformation,
they should
desire to be
active

evolved and
want to act, I
would stabilize
them with
nameless
simplicity. Even
nameless
simplicity would
not be wanted.
By not wanting,
there is calm,
and the world will
straighten itself.
up

ain to call them
back to unnamed
nature (to the
primordial
simplicity of the
Principle) each
time they showed
any tendency to
come out of this
state (by acting).
In this state of
unnamed nature
there are no
desires. When
there are no
desires all is
peaceful, and the
state is governed
by itself. up

s would thrive By
seeing what is
natural All
creation comes
alive Everyone
would be content
With living simply
every day
Desires would be
moderate And
peace would be
the only way

, I would restrain
them with
simplicity, which
has no name.
Simplicity, which
has no name, is
free of desires,
Being free of
desires, it is
tranquil. And the
world will be at
peace of its own
accord. up

Chapter 38

You needn't
search for power
You already have
it all To seek
outside your empty
core Is looking for
a fall The seer
doesn't do a thing
But sees that all is
finished Foolish
people run about
And leave totality
diminished
Goodness must be
doing And justice
never is complete

Propriety can't
satisfy Obedience
is forced defeat
When totality is
lost Goodness
comes to take its
place Followed by
propriety
Bewilderment and
end of grace The
seer sees
periphery But also
sees the open
core And thus the
seer sees the
whole And dwells
therein
forevermore

Chapter 39

If you stay with
clear awareness
The sky is open,
pure and
spacious The
earth is firm and
friendly too
Activity is
efficacious But
depart from
clarity The purest
sky is torn apart
The earth is so
divided Felicity
must fl

ee your heart
The seer knows
humility Doesn't
argue or cajole
Doesn't discard
anything Or
mutilate the
whole The seer
doesn't show at
all Doesn't
sparkle like a
jewel The seer's
vast immensity Is
truly less than
minuscule

Chapter 40

Return Is the Movement of the Way Return is the movement of the Way; yielding is the func

Going back (towards the Principle) is the type of movement characteristic of those who conform themselves to the Principle. Attenuation is the result of their being conformed to the Principle

All is born of emptiness Manifests and has its day Then

Reversion is the action of dao. In dao the only motion is a return; and the one useful quality is named soft [or polite] gentleness, So polite or we

Reversion is the action of Tao. Weakness is the function of Tao. All t

tion of the Way. All things in the world are born of being; being is born of nonbeing. up

. Considering all that exists is born of simple being, and that being is born of formless non-being, they tend, in diminishing themselves without cease, to go back to primordial simplicity. up

yields and surrenders Returns and dies away Commentary

ak gentleness [or humility] is the function of dao. The creatures and things of this world come from being. And being from not-yet-being. though all

hings in the world come from being. And being comes from non-being. up

Chapter 41

When seers see
their nothingness
They never let it
out of sight But
others see it now
and then And miss
out on its true
delight Still others
only laugh it off
And look at it with
ridicule It wouldn't
be the real truth If
it weren't laughed
at by the fool The
brightest way
seems darkness
Just going

on seems like
retreat The simple
way seems difficult
Capacity seems
like defeat Clarity
can seem obscure
And love seem not
to care Totality
seems not enough
And truth can
seem to err
Awareness doesn't
have a name To
all appearances is
null Yet it
produces
everything And so
this empty place is
full

Chapter 42

The Way
Produces One
The Way
produces one;
one produces
two, two produce
three, three
produce all
beings: all beings
bear yin and
embrace yang,
with a mellowing
energy for
harmony. The
things people
dislike are only to
be alone,
lacking,

When the Principle
has emitted its
virtue, the latter
begins to evolve
according to two
alternating
modalities. This
evolution produces
(or condenses) the
median air
(tenuous matter).
From tenuous
matter, under the
influence of the
two modalities yin
and yang, all
sentient beings are
produced. Coming
out from the yin
(from strength)
they pass to the
yang (to the

Awareness
comes from
nothingness So
all can see it's
plainly one
Contains all
opposition Ten
thousand things
are now begun
All these things
embrace the void
And face the
manifest
Achieving thus
true harmony
They find
existence truly

Tao produced the
One. The One
produced the two.
The two produced
the three. And the
three produced the
ten thousand
things. The ten
thousand things
carry the yin and
embrace the yang,
and through the
blending of the
material force they
achieve harmony.
People hate to be
children without
parents, lonely
people witho

and unworthy;
yet these are
what monarchs
call themselves.
Therefore people
may gain from
loss, and may
lose from gain.
What others
teach, I also
teach. The
strong cannot
master their
death: I take this
to be the father
of teachings. up

blessed No one
wants to be
considered
Empty and alone
Yet that's exactly
what the seers
Say they have
been shown And
violence is not
the way I give
you this
instruction Those
who live by
violence Will
bring about their
own destruction

ut spouses, or
men without food
to eat, And yet
kings and lords
call themselves by
these names.
Therefore it is
often the case that
things gain by
losing and lose by
gaining. What
others have
taught, I teach
also: "Violent and
fierce people do
not die a natural
death." I shall
make this the
father of my
teaching. up

Chapter 43

What Is Softest
in the World
What is softest in
the world drives
what is hardest
in the world.
Nonbeing enters
where there is no
r

Always and
everywhere it is
the soft that
wears the hard
(as water wears
stone).
Non-being
penetrates even
where there are
no cracks (as in
the most
homogeneous
bod

Overcome by
yielding The
weak can
overcome the
strong For only
absence can
provide The
place where
everything
belong

The softest things
in the world
overcome the
hardest things in
the world. The
softest substance
radiates through
the hardest. Also,
what's most
yielding can
eventually
overwhelm the
hardest. Formless
penetrates
no-crevice;
substanceless it
can enter where
there's no space;
all this could be
not-yet-being
entering and
jostling non-space.
That's how I know
the value of action
that's

The softest
things in the
world overcome
the hardest
things in the
world. Non-being
penetrates that in
which there is no
space. Through
this

oom; that is how
we know
noncontrivance
enhances.
Unspoken
guidance and
uncontrived
enhancement
are reached by
few in the world.
up

ies such as metal
and stone). From
that I conclude
the supreme
effectiveness of
non-action.
Silence and
inaction - few
men come to
understand their
effectiveness. up

s And thus it is
that I can see
The worthiness
of not contending
Yet few will ever
comprehend The
potency of
bending

actionless.
Through this I
[also] know the
benefit or
advantage of
taking no action.
There can be [sad]
teaching without
words. To teach
without words can
be best. Still few
can understand
such stuff. And
there can be solid
value in action
that's actionless,
or the advantage
of taking no action.
Yes, the [said]
benefit of taking no
action is without
compare. Few can
understand it.

I know the
advantage of
taking no action.
Few in the world
can understand
the teaching
without words
and the
advantage of
taking no action.
up

Chapter 44

Name or Body
Which is closer,
your name or
your body?
Which is more,
your body or
your
possessions?
Which is more
destructive, gain
or loss? Extreme
fondness means
great expense,
and abun

Is not the body
more important
than reputation?
Is life not of more
consideration
than wealth? Is it
wise to risk a
great loss for a
small
advantage? He
who is a great
lover, wears out

Which of these
means more to
you Integrity or
reputation? Are
gain and loss not
equally
Responsible for
limitation?
Everything that
you possess Is
surely transitory
Just be pl

Which does one
love more, fame
or one's own life?
Which is more
valuable, one's
own life or
wealth? Which is
worse, gain or
loss? Therefore
he who has
lavish desires will
spen

dant possessions
mean much loss.
If you know when
you have
enough, you will
not be disgraced.
If you know when
to stop, you will
not be
endangered. It is
possible thereby
to live long. up

(his heart). He
who amasses
great wealth,
heads toward
ruin (by theft or
confiscation).
Whereas he who
is modest courts
no disgrace; he
who is moderate
does not perish,
but endures. up

eased with
emptiness And
witness inner
bliss and glory
You know that
you are always
safe If only you
can be contented
With awareness
as capacity And
with all that is
presented

d extravagantly.
He who hoards
will lose most
heavily. He who
is contented
suffers no
disgrace. He who
knows when to
stop is free from
danger.
Therefore he can
long endure. up

Chapter 45

Great
Completeness
Seems
Incomplete Great
completeness
seems
incomplete; its
use is never
exhausted. Great
fullness seems
empty; its use is
never ended.
Great directness
s

Accomplished,
beneath an
imperfect
exterior. Giving,
(of himself)
without
becoming worn
out. Filled up,
without
appearing to be
so, And pouring
out without being
emptied. Very
straight, beneath
a bent air; most
able, behind an
awkward
appearanc

Wholeness
seems like
imperfection Yet
its usefulness is
sure Fullness
seems quite
empty But it is
certain to endure
True straightness
can seem twisted
True wisdom
does not seem to
know G

What is most
perfect seems to
be incomplete;
But its utility is
unimpaired.
What is most full
seems to be
empty; But its
usefulness is
inexhaustible.
What is most
straight seems to
be crooked. The
greatest s

eems restrained,
great skill seems
inept, great
eloquence
seems
inarticulate.
Movement
overcomes cold,
stillness
overcomes heat.
Clear stillness is
right for the
world. up

e; highly
perspicacious,
with an
embarrassed
exterior. This is
the Sage.
Movement beats
the cold (warms
one up), rest
overcomes heat
(refreshes). The
withdrawn life of
the Sage rectifies
all the empire
(strikes at the
root of its
depravation. up

reat eloquence
seems halting
Great darkness
seems to be
aglow Can you
see that
emptiness
Contains all
oppositions? Like
hot and cold and
fast and slow?
All differences
and all
conditions?

kill seems to be
clumsy. The
greatest
eloquence
seems to stutter.
Hasty movement
overcomes cold,
(But) tranquility
overcomes heat.
By being greatly
tranquil, One is
qualified to be
the ruler of the
world. up

Chapter 46

When the World
Has the Way
When the world
has the Way,
running horses
are retired to till
the fields. When
the world lacks
the Way,
war-horses are
bred in the
countryside. No c

When the
Principle reigns
(in perfect
peace), war
horses work in
the fields. When
the Principle is
forgotten, (war
horses are the
order of the day)
And they are
raised even in
the suburbs of
the towns. To
give in to one's
covetousness
(And th

When the
absolute is
cherished
Horses graze on
the open green
When the
absolute is lost
Only steeds of
war are see

When Tao
prevails in the
world, galloping
horses are
turned back to
fertilize (the
fields with the
dung). When Tao
does not prevail
in the world, war
horses thrive in
the suburbs.
There is no

crime is greater
than approving of
greed; no
calamity is
greater than
discontent, no
fault is greater
than
possessiveness.
So the
satisfaction of
contentment is
always enough.
up

is includes the
mania for waging
war), is the worst
of crimes. Not to
know how to
control oneself,
is the worst of
nasty things. The
worst of faults is
to want more,
always. Those
who know how to
say 'enough is
enough', are
always content.
up

n No calamity
exceeds desire
And always
wanting more
Can you not see
you have enough
And live in
plenitude galore?

calamity greater
than lavish
desires. There is
no greater guilt
than
discontentment.
And there is no
greater disaster
than greed. He
who is contented
with contentment
is always
contented. up

Chapter 47

Without Even
Going out the
Door They know
the world without
even going out
the door. They
see the sky and
its pattern
without even
looking out t

Without going
out by the door,
one can know
the whole world;
without looking
through the
window, one can
become aware of
the way of
heaven
(principles which
rule all things). -
The further one
goes, the I

No need to go
outside a door
To see totality Or
look out of a
window For
seeing what will
always be Going

One can know
whats happening
all over the world
without going out
of doors. One
can see the dao
of the big wide
beyond here
without looking
out of ones
windows, and
see all the ways
of that
beyond-here.
Then,

One may know
the world without
going out of
doors. One may
see the Way of
Heaven without
looking through
the windows.
The further one
go

he window. The
further out it
goes, the less
knowledge is;
therefore sages
know without
going, name
without seeing,
complete without
striving. up

ess one learns.
The Sage gets
there without
having taken a
step to reach it.
He knows before
having seen,
through superior
principles. He
achieves, without
having acted,
through his
transcendent
action. up

out you go astray
At home and
center all is one
The seer doesn't
have to do To
see that
everything is
done

the further one
travels the less
one knows. So
the wise man
can [at times]
arrive without
going and know
without going
about; he can
understand much
without seeing -
or achieve much
without [visible]
action.

es, the less one
knows. Therefore
the sage knows
without going
about,
Understands
without seeing,
And
accomplishes
without any
action. up

Chapter 48

For Learning You
Gain Daily For
learning you gain
daily; for the Way
you lose daily.
Losing and
losing, thus you
reach
noncontrivance;
be uncontrived,
and n

By studying,
every day one
increases
(useless and
injurious
particular
notions, in one's
memory); by
concentrating on
the Principle,
they are
diminished every
day. Pushed to
the limit, this
diminution ends
in non-action,
(the

In going after
learning
Something's
added every day
For resting in the
ultimate
Everything must
drop away Day
by day do less
and less Until
nothingness is
seen All occu

The pursuit of
learning is to
increase day
after day. The
pursuit of Tao is
to decrease day
after day. It is to
decrease and
further decrease
until one reaches
the point of
taking no action.
No

othing is not
done. Taking the
world is always
done by not
making anything
of it. For when
something is
made of it, that is
not enough to
take the world.
up

consequence of
the absence of
particular ideas).
Now there is
nothing that
non-action
(letting things go)
cannot sort out. It
is through
non-action that
one wins the
empire. To act, in
order to win it,
results in failure.
up

rs quite on its
own A doer need
not intervene
Allow all things to
run their course
If you want to be
proficient Make a
fuss and bother
And existence
will be
insufficient

action is
undertaken, And
yet nothing is left
undone. An
empire is often
brought to order
by having no
activity. If one
(likes to)
undertake
activity, he is not
qualified to
govern the
empire. up

Chapter 49

Sages Have No Fixed Mind
Sages have no fixed mind; they make the minds of the people their mind: they improve the good, and also improve those who are not good; that virtue is good. They make sure of the true, and they

The Sage has no definite will of his own, he accommodates himself to the will of the people. He treats the good and the bad equally well, which is the true practice of goodness. He trusts the sincere and insincere alike, which is t

The seer doesn't own a thought For thoughts do not reside within Thoughts concern ten thousand things And that's the way it's always been The seer doesn't rush to judge And treats all people well Considers no one bad or good Attracts but never does repel T

The sage has no fixed (personal) ideas. He regards the people's ideas as his own. I treat those who are good with goodness. And I also treat those who are not good with goodness. Thus goodness is attained. I am honest to those who are honest, And I am also hon

make sure of the untrue too; that virtue is sure. The relation of sages to the world is one of concern: they cloud their minds for the world; all people pour into their ears and eyes, and sages render them innocent. up

he true practice of trust. In this mixed-up world, the Sage is without any emotion, and has the same feelings for all. All men fix their eyes and ears on him. He treats them like children, (Daoism kindness, slightly disdainful). up

he seer trusts things as they are And takes all people at their word Giving trust to everyone Knows faithfulness will be returned The seer turns your view around So you can never be beguiled And gives you back all that you lost The vision of a little child

est to those who are not honest. Thus honesty is attained. The sage, in the government of his empire, has no subjective viewpoint. His mind forms a harmonious whole with that of his people. The all lend their eyes and ears, And he treats them all as infants. up

Chapter 50

From Life into
Death Exiting life,
we enter death.
The followers of
life are three out of
ten, the followers
of death are three
out of ten; in the
lives of the people,
the dying grounds
on which they are
agitated are also
three out of ten.
What is the
reason? Because
of the seriousness
with which they tak

Men go forth into
life, And return in
death. Out of ten
men, three prolong
their life (through
cleanliness), three
hasten their death
(through their
excesses), three
compromise their
life by the
attachment they
have to it, (And
only one stays
alive until his term,
because he is not
attached to it). He
who is not
attached to his life,
does

Between the time
when they are
born And the time
that they will die
Three in ten will
follow life Three
others only will
deny Three others
are so casual They
live as though
they're passing
through But one
remains who
clearly sees
There's not a
single thin

Man comes in to
life and goes out to
death. Three out of
ten are
companions of life.
Three out of ten
are companions of
death. And three
out of ten in their
lives lead from
activity to death.
And for what
reason? Because
of man's intensive
striving after life. I
have heard that
one who is a good
preserver of his lif

e life as life. It has
been said that
those who
maintain life well
do not meet rhinos
or tigers on land
and do not arm
themselves in war.
There is no way
for rhinos to gore
them; there is no
way for tigers to
claw them; there is
no way for
weapons to get at
them. Why?
Because they
have no dying
ground. up

not turn aside to
avoid an
encounter with a
rhinoceros or a
tiger; he throws
himself into the
fray without
armour or
weapons; And he
comes to no harm
because he is
proof against the
rhinoceros horn,
the tiger's claws,
And weapons of
combat. Why is
this? ... Because,
exteriorized
through his
indifference, death
cannot take a hold
on him. up

g to do Can you be
like the one who
sees The world
emerging on its
own? What's
needed for each
moment Arises
from the great
unknown This one
doesn't have a fear
Of weaponry or
wild beast These
enemies can't
harm the one
Whose separate
self is long
deceased

e will not meet
tigers or wild
buffaloes, And in
fighting will not try
to escape from
weapons of war.
The wild buffalo
cannot butt its
horns against him,
The tiger cannot
fasten its claws in
him, And weapons
of war cannot
thrust their blades
into him. And for
what reason?
Because in him
there is no room
for death. up

Chapter 51

The Way Gives Birth The Way gives birth, virtue nurtures, things form, momentum completes. Therefore all beings honor the Way and value its Virtue. The honor of the Way and the value of Virtue are not granted by anyone, but are always naturally

The Principle gives life to beings, then its Virtue nourishes them, until the completion of their nature, until the perfection of their faculties. Therefore all beings venerate the Principle and its Virtue. No one has the eminence of the Principle and its Virtue conferred on them; they have it always, natura

Everything arises From this total emptiness Is nourished and completed And finds creation blessed All things arise from nothingness Are cared for by existence Which fre

Tao produces them. Virtue fosters them. Matter gives them physical form. The circumstances and tendencies complete them. Therefore the ten thousand things esteem Tao and honour virtue. Tao is esteemed and virtue is honoured without anyone's order! They always come spontaneously. Therefore the Tao produces them and virt

so. So the Way gives birth and nurtures, makes grow and develops, completes and matures, builds up and breaks down. It produces but does not possess; it acts without presumption, it fosters growth without ruling. This is called hidden Virtue. up

lly. The Principle gives life; its Virtue gives growth, protects, perfects, matures, maintains, And covers (all beings). When they are born, it does not monopolize them; it lets them act freely, without exploiting them; it lets them grow, without tyrannizing them. This is the action of transcendent Virtue. up

ely gives what is required For bountiful subsistence Existence does not make a claim On what it has created It nourishes and serves and leads Is honored and appreciated

ue fosters them. They rear them and develop them. They give them security and give them peace. They nurture them and protect them. (Tao) produces them but does not take possession of them. It acts, but does not rely on its own ability. It leads them but does not master them. This is called profound and secret virtue. up

Chapter 52

The World Has a Beginning The world has a beginning that is the mother of the world. Once you've found the mother, thereby you know the child. Once you know the child, you return to keep the mother, not perishing though the body die. Close your eyes, shut your doors, and you do not toil all you

All things emerge from nullity The only derivation Of everything that manifests The source of all creation Stay in touch with origin There's nothing that you need deny Seeing your totality You will not fear to die Do not be in haste

There was a beginning of the universe Which may be called the Mother of the Universe. He who has found the mother (Tao) And thereby understands her sons (things), And having understood the sons, Still keeps to its mother, Will be free from danger throughout his lifetime. Close the mouth. Shut the doors (of cunning and desires). And to the e

r life. Open your eyes, carry out your affairs, and you are not saved all your life. Seeing the small is called clarity; keeping flexible is called strength. Using the shining radiance, you return again to the light, not leaving anything to harm yourself. This is called entering the eternal. up

to speak And always guard the senses You will find your heart at peace And in the place where all commences See the subtle and the clear It is the empty source of light There is no danger in this place That is forever in plain sight

nd of life there will be (peace) without toil. Open the mouth. Meddle with affairs. And to the end of life there will be no salvation. Seeing what is small is called enlightenment. Keeping to weakness is called strength. Use the light. Revert to enlightenment. And thereby avoid danger to one's life - This is called practicing the eternal. up

Chapter 53

Causing One
Flashes Causing
one flashes of
knowledge to
travel the Great
Way, only its
application
demands care.
The Great Way
is quite even, yet
people prefer
byways. When
courts are
extremely
fastidious, the
fields are s

He who has little
wisdom, should
conform himself to
the great Principle.
He should take
care to avoid any
irksome boasting.
But to this wide
road many prefer
the narrow
sidetracks. (Few
men walk along
the way of obscure
disinterestedness.
They prefer the
narrow tracks of
their vanity, their
own advantage.
This is how the
princes of these
times act). When
the palaces are
too well kept up,
the fields

This way is wide
and easy Yet
people love to
stray They love
to take the
sidetracks And
wander from the
way When the
few are rich and
wealthy Living
way above their
needs The
granaries are
empty And the
fields are full of
weeds

If I had but little
knowledge I
should, in
walking on a
broad way, Fear
getting off the
road. Broad
ways are
extremely even,
But people are
fond of bypaths.
The courts are
exceedingly
splendid, While
the fields are
exceedingly
weedy, And the
gran

eriously
neglected, and
the granaries are
very empty; they
wear colorful
clothing and
carry sharp
swords, eat and
drink to their fill
and possess
more than
enough. This is
called the vanity
of thieves; it is
not the Way. up

go uncultivated
and the granaries
empty, (because
the farm workers
are requisitioned
for forced labour).
Dressing
magnificently,
wearing a sharp
sword, stuffing
oneself with food
and drink,
amassing wealth
to the extent of not
knowing what to
do with it (as do
the princes of
these times), is
being like a
brigand (who
ostentatiously
plays with his loot).
Such conduct is
opposed to the
Principle. up

When rulers
spend on
weapons And
implements of
war It's a never
ending circle Of
ever wanting
more When the
rich have all
abundance What
remains must
surely dwindle
Having more
than you can use
Is thievery and
fraud and
swindle

aries are
exceedingly
empty. Elegant
clothes are worn,
Sharp weapons
are carried, Food
and drinks are
enjoyed beyond
limit, And wealth
and treasures
are accumulated
in excess. This is
robbery and
extravagance.
This is indeed
not Tao (the
Way). up

Chapter 54

Good Construction
Does Not Fall
Down Good
construction does
not fall down, a
good embrace
does not let go;
their heirs honor
them unceasingly.
Cultivate it in
yourself, and that
virtue is real;
cultivate it in the
home, and that
virtue is abundant;
cultivate it in the
locality, and that
virtue lasts;
cultivate i

He who builds on
disinterestedness
will not find his
work destroyed.
He who keeps
himself
disinterested will
not lose what he
has. His sons and
his grandsons will
make offerings to
him without
interruption (that is
to say, they will
succeed him and
enjoy the fruit of
his works). First of
all one should
conform oneself to
the Principle;
afterwards, this
conformity will
spread spontane

Hold fast to this
awareness Seeing
that it is your root It
will not ever slip
away This ever
present absolute It
cannot be
uprooted It's
always held in
veneration
Discovered very
close at hand In
every generation
Allow its presence
in your life
Awareness real
and profound All

t in the nation, and
that virtue is rich;
cultivate it in the
world, and that
virtue is universal.
So observe
yourself by
yourself, observe
the home by the
home, observe the
locality by the
locality, observe
the nation by the
nation, observe
the world by the
world. How do I
know the world is
as it is? By this. up

ously, by itself, to
one's family,
district, principality,
And to the empire;
(like radiant heat
coming from a
central hearth).
Through one's
own nature, one
understands those
of other
individuals, And of
all individual
collectivities such
as families,
districts,
principalities, And
the empire. How
can one know the
nature of an entire
empire? ... By this
(through one's
own nature). up

ow it in the family
Its blessings will
abound And if you
care to share it
With neighbor and
with friend Its
potency will
multiply With
benefits that never
end You ask me
how I know it's true
It isn't something I
mistook Well
nothing is more
obvious The only
thing I do is look

Chapter 55

The Richness of Subliminal Virtue
The richness of subliminal virtue is comparable to an infant: poisonous creatures do not sting it, wild beasts do not claw it, predatory birds do not grab it. Its tendons are flexible, yet its grip is firm. Even while it knows not of the mating of male and female, its genitals get aroused; this is the epitome of

He who holds himself in perfect Virtue (without lust or anger) is like the new-born child whom the scorpion does not bite, the tiger does not devour, the vulture does not seize, whom all respect. A child's bones are weak, its tendons are feeble, but it grasps objects strongly (just as its soul and body are held together by force). He has not yet any notion of the act of generation, And, in consequence, keeps h

One who sees full emptiness Is like a child just born With muscles weak and bones so soft Yet with a grip that's strong The newborn hasn't been fulfilled Its nature is pure vacancy Nullity and nothingness And potent spontaneity It

He who possesses virtue in abundance May be compared to an infant. Poisonous insects will not sting him. Fierce beasts will not seize him. Birds of prey will not strike him. His bones are weak, his sinews tender, but his grasp is firm. He does not yet know the union of male and female, But his organ is aroused, This means that his essence is at its height. He may cry all day without becoming hoarse, This means

vitality. It can cry all day without choking or getting hoarse; this is the epitome of harmony. Knowing harmony is called constancy, knowing constancy is called clarity; enhancing life is called propitious, the mind mastering energy is called strong. When beings climax in power, they wane; this is called being unguided. The unguided die early. up

can scream and cry all day And yet it never does get hoarse It only does what naturally Emerges from the inner source To see this inner nature Is seeing in a way that's bold Into the only place there is That cannot possibly grow old

that his (natural) harmony is perfect. To know harmony means to be in accord with the eternal. To be in accord with the eternal means to be enlightened. To force the growth of life means ill omen. For the mind to employ the vital force without restraint means violence. After all things reach their prime, they begin to grow old, Which means being contrary to Tao. Whatever is contrary to Tao will soon perish. up

Chapter 56

Those Who Know Do Not Say Those who know do not say; those who say do not know. Close the senses, shut the doors; blunt the sharpness, resolve the complications; harmonize the light, assimilate to the world. This i

He who knows (the Principle), does not speak. He keeps his mouth closed, controls his breathing, blunts his activity, rescues himself from any complication, tempers his light, And mingles with people. This is mysterious union (wit

Those who know don't like to say Those who say don't know Close the mouth and guard the senses You'll see more than what's on show Untie tangles, dim the glare Dull the sharp

He who knows doesn't speak (artfully). He who speaks hardly knows. Fill your openings, shut the doors, Dull all nasty edges. Untie all tangles. Temper or soften all glaring light. Submerge its turmoil as unified with the world: Let all chaotic hustle and bustle be smoothed down. This is the called the mysterious [Vossing] levelling for bland unity or deep insider identification. Love and hatred can barely aff

He who knows does not speak. He who speaks does not know. Close the mouth. Shut the doors. Blunt the sharpness. Untie the tangles. Soften the light. Become one with the dusty world. This is called the profound identification. Therefore it is imp

s called mysterious sameness. It cannot be made familiar, yet cannot be estranged; it cannot be profited, yet cannot be harmed; it cannot be valued, yet cannot be demeaned. Therefore it is precious for the world. up

h the Principle). No one can attach himself (by doing favours) to such a man, nor repulse him (by treating him badly). He is indifferent to gain or loss, exaltation or humiliation. Being thus, he is the most noble in the world. up

and join the dust Abide in primal unity And then do what you must You cannot hold it or let go It can't be blamed or praised In all-embracing oneness Be astonished and amazed

ossible either to be intimate and close to him or to be distant and indifferent to him. It is impossible either to benefit him or to harm him. It is impossible either to honour him or disgrace him. For this reason he is honoured by the world. up

Chapter 57

Govern Nations by Normalcy Use straightforwardness for civil government, use surprise for military operations; use noninvolvement to take the world. How do I know this? The more taboos there are in the world, the poorer the populace is; the more crafts the people have the more exotic things are produced; the more laws

One can govern with rectitude, one can wage war with competence, but it takes non-action to win and hold the empire. How do I know that this is so? From what I am going to say: The more rules there are, the less people enrich themselves. The more taxes there are, the less order there is. The more ingenious inventions there are, the fewer serious and useful objects there a

To truly lead with fairness You must put aside control Abandon imposition Make spontaneity your goal The more you try to run their lives With rules and prohibition The poorer people's lives become The more they live in opposition The more you deal with others With cunning and with guile The more that other people say Our lives are not wo

Govern the state with correctness. Operate the army with surprise tactics. Administer the empire by engaging in no activity. How do I know that this should be so? Through this: The more taboos and prohibitions there are in the world, The poorer the people will be. The more sharp weapons the people have, The more troubled the state will be. The more cunning and skill a man possesses, The more vicio

are promulgated, the greater the number of thieves. Therefore the sage says, I contrive nothing, and the people are naturally civilized; I am fond of tranquility, and the people are naturally upright. I have nothing to do, and the people are naturally enriched; I have no desire, and the people are naturally simple. up

re. The more detailed the penal code, the more thieves abound. Multiplication ruins everything. Therefore the programme of the Sage is quite the contrary. Not acting, And the people amend themselves. Staying peaceful, And the people rectify themselves. Doing nothing, And the people enrich themselves. Wishing for nothing, And the people come back to natural spontaneity. up

rthwhile The more you hoard your treasures The more you're giving hope to thieves The more you sharpen weapons The more the country grieves Do nothing and see all is done And everyone is true Drop the rules and people owe Prosperity to you Just let go of all desire And people will return To natural and simple ways To life without concern

Chapter 58

When the Government Is Unobtrusive When the government is unobtrusive, the people are pure. When the government is invasive, the people are wanting. Calamity is what fortune depends upon; fortune is what calamity subdues. Who knows how it will all end? Is there

When the government is simple, the people abound in virtue. When the government is political, the people lack virtue. Good and bad succeed one another, alternately. Who will discern the heights? (of this circular movement, of good and evil. It is very delicate, an excess or a default changing the moral entity). In many the right measure is lacking. In

Let your lead be gentle And people will be satisfied Let it be severe and harsh And be rejected and defied Happiness may reign today But who knows what tomorrow holds? Sadness too will

When the government is non-discriminative and dull, The people are contented and generous. When the government is searching and discriminative, The people are disappointed and contentious. Calamity is that upon which happiness depends; Happiness is that in which calamity is latent. Who knows when the limit will be reached? Is there no correctness (used to go

no right and wrong? The orthodox also becomes unorthodox, the good also becomes ill; people's confusion is indeed long-standing. Therefore sages are upright without causing injury, honest without hurting, direct but not tactless, illumined but not flashy. up

some an exaggerated righteousness degenerates into a mania. In others an exaggerated goodness becomes extravagance. (Points of view changing in consequence. For a long time now, men have thus been crazy. The Sage takes them as they are). Taking them to task, he is not sharp or cutting. Straight, he is not rude. Enlightened, he does not humiliate. up

I have its time As all ten thousand things unfold The seer's sight is sharp and pointed But it does not cut or pierce The seer sees and shows the truth This gentle way is never fierce

vern the world)? Then the correct again becomes the perverse. And the good again will become evil. The people have been deluded for a long time. Therefore the sage is as pointed as a square but does not pierce. He is as acute as a knife but does not cut. He is as straight as an unbent line but does not extend. He is as bright as light but does not dazzle. up

Chapter 59

To Govern the Human and
Serve the Divine
To govern the human and serve the divine, nothing compares to frugality. Only frugality brings early recovery; early recovery means buildup of power. Build up virtue, and you master all. When you master a

The essential for co-operation with heaven in the government of men, is to moderate one's action. This moderation should be the prime care. It procures perfect efficacy, which succeeds in everything, ev

To serve and care for others
With restraint and moderation
Stay centered in the here and now
And free o

To rule people and to serve Heaven there is nothing better than to be frugal. Only by being frugal can one recover quickly. To recover quickly means to accumulate virtue heavily. By the heavy accumulation of virtue one can overcome everything. If one can overcome everything, then he will acquire a capaci

ll, no one knows your limit. When no one knows your limit, you can maintain a nation. When you maintain the matrix of a nation, you can last long. This is called making the root deep and the basis firm, the Way of long life and eternal vision. up

en the governing of the empire. He who possesses this mother of the empire (wise moderation), will last a long time. It is called the pivoting root, the solid trunk. It is the principle of perpetuity. up

f limitation If you keep returning To this your central root You will possess forever Awareness undilute

ty the limit of which is beyond anyone's knowledge. When his capacity is beyond anyone's knowledge, he is fit to rule a state. He who possesses the Mother (Tao) of the state will last long. This means that the roots are deep and the stalks are firm, which is the way of long life and everlasting vision. up

Chapter 60

Governing a
Large Nation Is
like Cooking
Small Fry
Governing a
large nation is
like cooking little
fish. When the
world is ruled by
the Way, the
ghosts are
powerless. It is
not that the
ghosts are power

To govern a great
state, one should
act like someone
cooking a very
small fish (very
delicately,
otherwise they
break up). When a
state is governed
according to the
Principle,
phantoms do not
appear there to
harm the people,
because the Sage
who governs does
not harm t

It's best to lead a
large domain As
you would cook a
little fish Don't
poke and prod or
you are bound
To spoil the
country and the
dish Just stay
open and aware
And evil c

Ruling a big
country is like
cooking a small
fish. If Tao is
employed to rule
the empire,
Spiritual beings
will lose their
supernatural
power. Not that
they lose their
spiritual power,
But their spiritual
power can no l

less; their spirits
do not harm the
people. Not only
do the spirits not
harm the people;
sages do not
harm the people
either. Because
the two do not
harm each other,
their virtues
ultimately
combine. up

he people. Not that
the spirits have no
more powers, But
their powers will
not harm men./
Neither will they
harm men, Nor will
the Sage harm the
people. The merit
of this double
tranquility (on the
part of the living
and the dead)
comes back,
therefore, to the
Sage. up

annot get a hold
Cannot find a
home in you
Even evil's not
that bold At
center you harm
no one And no
one's able to
harm you This
kind of
reciprocity
Creates the
world anew

onger harm
people. Not only
will their
supernatural
power not harm
people, But the
sage also will not
harm people.
When both do
not harm each
other, Virtue will
be accumulated
in both for the
benefit (of the
people). up

Chapter 61

A Great Nation
Flows Downward
A great nation
flows downward
into intercourse
with the world. The
female of the world
always prevails
over the male by
stillness. Because
stillness is
considered lower,
by lowering itself
to a small nation a
great nation takes
a small nation; by
being lower than a

If a great state
lowers itself, like
those holes in
which water
accumulates,
everyone will
come to it. It will
belike the
universal female.
In her apparent
passivity and
inferiority, the
female is superior
to the male (for it is
she who gives
birth). On condition
of knowing how to
lower itself, a gr

A great domain
is like the sea
Whose power
comes from lying
low And due to
this humility Its
greatness has to
grow A small
domain can lie
low too
Acknowledging
its low

A big country may
be compared to
the lower part of a
river. It is the
converging point of
the world; It is the
female of the
world. The female
always overcomes
the male by
tranquillity, And by
tranquillity she is
underneath. A big
state can take over
a small state if it
places itself below
the small state;
And the small
state can take over
a big state if it
places itse

great nation a
small nation takes
a great nation. So
one takes by
lowering itself,
another takes by
being lower. A
great nation wants
no more than to
include and
nurture people; a
small nation wants
no more than to
admit and serve
people. Both get
what they want, so
the great should
be below. up

eat state will win
over lesser states,
which in their turn,
will lower
themselves,
seeking its
protection. For this
to be realized, only
one thing is
needed, but it is
essential. It is that
the great state
deigns to lower
itself before the
lesser ones. (if it is
proud and hard,
there is no hope).
up

location
Surrender and
humility Give rise
to exaltation If
you lie low you
too arise To
uppermost
position For
everyone's
attracted to One
who doesn't fear
submission

If below the big
state. Thus some,
by placing
themselves below,
take over (others),
And some, by
being (naturally)
low, take over
(other states).
After all, what a
big state wants is
but to annex and
herd others, And
what a small state
wants is merely to
join and serve
others. Since both
big and small
states get what
they want, The big
state should place
itself low. up

Chapter 62

The Way Is the
Pivot of All Things
The Way is the
pivot of all things:
the treasure of
good people, the
safeguard of those
who are not good.
Fine words can be
sold, honored acts
can oppress
people; why
should people who
are not good
abandon them?
Therefore to
establish an
emperor and se

I'm at the center
and the source Of
all ten thousand
things Where I
receive the
benefits That pure
awareness brings
These benefits
belong to all To
good and bad the
same For nature
gives you what
you need With no
regard for praise
or blame Words
and deeds of
excellence May
bring you honor
and acclaim B

Tao is the
storehouse of all
things. It is the
good man's
treasure and the
bad man's refuge.
Fine words can
buy honour, And
fine deeds can
gain respect from
others. Even if a
man is bad, when
has (Tao) rejected
him? Therefore on
the occasion of
crowning an
emperor or
installing the three
minister

t up high officials,
one may have a
great jewel and
drive a team of
horses, but that is
not as good as
advancing calmly
on this Way. Why
did the ancients
value this Way?
By it one can
attain without long
seeking and
escape from the
faults one has;
therefore it is
valued by the
world. up

ut nature values
each alike And is
indifferent to fame
When new leaders
are installed Don't
send gifts or lofty
praise Stay
centered in the
unity Provided by
the inward gaze
Why should you
esteem the void? It
does away with
imperfection
Those who seek
are bound to find It
disappears on
close inspection

s, Rather than
present four large
pieces of jade
preceded by
teams of four
horses, It is better
to kneel and offer
this Tao. Why did
the ancients highly
value this Tao?
Did they not say,
"Those who seek
shall have it and
those who sin shall
be freed"? For this
reason it is valued
by the world. up

Chapter 63

Do Nondoing Do
nondoing, strive
for nonstriving,
savor the
flavorless, regard
the small as
important, make
much of little,
repay enmity with
virtue; plan for
difficulty when it is
still easy, do the
great while it is still
small. The most
difficult things in
the world must be
done while they
are easy; the
greatest things

To act without
acting; to be busy
without being
busy; to taste
without tasting; to
look equally on the
great, the small,
the many and the
few; to be
indifferent to
thanks and
reproaches; this is
how the Sage
acts. He only sets
about difficult
complications
through their
easiest details,
and only applies
himself to great
problem

Begin with the
easy And do
without doing
There isn't a
thing That you
should be
pursuing Begin
with the simple
There's no need
attacking Your
greatness will lie
In all that you're
lacking Tackle
problems when

Act without action.
Do without ado.
Taste without
tasting. Whether it
is big or small,
many or few,
repay hatred with
virtue. Prepare for
the difficult while it
is still easy. Deal
with the big while it
is still small.
Difficult
undertakings have
always started with
what is easy. And
great undertakings
have always
started

in the world must
be done while they
are small.
Because of this
sages never do
great things; that is
why they can fulfill
their greatness. If
you agree too
easily, you'll be
little trusted; if you
take it easy a lot,
you'll have a lot of
problems.
Therefore it is
through difficulty
that sages end up
without problems.
up

ms in their weak
beginnings. The
Sage never
undertakes
anything great,
and that is why he
makes great
things. He who
promises much,
cannot keep his
word; he who
embarrasses
himself with too
many things, even
easy things, never
succeeds in
anything. The
Sage keeps clear
of difficulty,
therefore he never
has any difficulties.
up

they're small And
still subject to
solution The
largest problem
is resolved By
simple deeds of
diminution Can
you center every
day And see all
the seers see
Empty here and
brimming there A
marvelous
asymmetry?

with what is small.
Therefore the sage
never strives for
the great, And
thereby the great
is achieved. He
who makes rash
promises surely
lacks faith. He who
takes things too
easily will surely
encounter much
difficulty. For this
reason even the
sage regards
things as difficult.
And therefore he
encounters no
difficulty. up

Chapter 64

To keep the
peace is easy
Begin before a
problem stirs
Handle things
before they
happen And
trouble before it
occurs Be calm
and conquer
worries Before
they can proceed
The very largest
tree begins As
just a tiny seed It
takes

a single step to
start A journey of
a thousand miles
And just one
brick to start to
build The
grandest
domiciles Let
things happen as
they will You do
not need to
interfere See that
you do nothing
That causes
discord to appear

Chapter 65

Good Practitioners of the Way in Ancient Times In ancient times, good practitioners of the Way did not use it to enlighten the people, but to make them unsophisticated. When people are unruly, it is because of their sophistication. So to govern a country by cunning is to rob the countr

In antiquity, those who conformed themselves to the Principle did not seek to make the people clever, but aimed at keeping them simple. When people are difficult to govern, it is because they know too much. Those who claim to procure the good of a co

Those of old who found the way Could see their inner core They saw that it was hidden And didn't bring it to the fore When people think they know the truth They want all others to

In ancient times those who practiced Tao well Did not seek to enlighten people, but to make them ignorant. People are difficult to govern because they have too much knowledge. Therefore he who rules the state through knowledge is a robber of the state; He who rules a state not through knowl

y. Not using cunning to govern a country is good fortune for the country. To know these two is also a model. Being always aware of the model is called hidden virtue. Hidden virtue is deep, far-reaching, in contrast to ordinary people. Only when it is thus does it reach great accord. up

untry by disseminating instruction, are wrong, and ruin the country. This is the formula of mysterious action, of great profundity, of great bearing. It is not to the taste of (the curious) but, thanks to it, everything turns out well, peacefully. up

concur But they are happy and content When they remain unsure Don't try to lead with cleverness Prefer instead simplicity It's obvious that truth must lie In nothingness and clarity

edge is a blessing to the state. One who knows these two things also (knows) the standard. Always to know the standard is called profound and secret virtue. Virtue becomes deep and far-reaching, And with it all things return to their original state. Then complete harmony will be reached. up

Chapter 66

Rivers and Seas
Are Lords of the
Hundred Valleys
The reason why
rivers and seas
Can be lords of the
hundred valleys is
that they lower
themselves to
them well;
therefore they can
be lords of the
hundred valleys.
So when sages
wish to rise above
people, they lower
themselves to
them in their
speech. When the

The sea is large
and mighty
Because it lies
below The
streams and
rivers of the
world Thus
capturing their
flow If you want
to have your fill
Then you must
see that you are
hollow If you
want to lead the
way Then you
must be
prepared to
follow

The great rivers
and seas are
kings of all
mountains
streams Because
they skillfully stay
below them. That
is why they can
be their kings.
Therefore, in
order to be the
superior of the
people, One
must, in the use
of words, place
himself below th

you want to precede
people, they go
after them in
status. So when
sages rule, people
don't take it
gravely. And when
sages are in the
forefront, people
don't attack them.
Therefore the
world happily
backs them and
does not tire of
them. Because
they do not
contend, no one in
the world can
contend with them.
up

become the first,
he should put
himself in last
place, (and
continue to do so,
after he has been
exalted). He could
then be elevated
to the highest peak
without the people
feeling oppressed
by him; he could
be the first without
the people
complaining about
him. The whole
empire would
serve him with joy,
without becoming
weary of him. For,
not being opposed
to anyone, no one
would be opposed
to him. up

When you lead
you are above
But no one feels
put down And
when you must
be out in front
Know that no
one's losing
ground When
you see that
you're not built
For facing up or
confrontation No
one can contend
with you Who are
the ultimate
negation

em. And in order
to be ahead of
the people, One
must, in one's
own person,
follow them.
Therefore the
sage rejoices in
praising him
without getting
tired of it. It is
precisely
because he does
not compete that
the world cannot
compete with
him. up

Chapter 67

Everyone Says
Everyone in the
world says my
Way is great, but it
seems
incomparable. It is
just because it is
great that it seems
incomparable:
when comparisons
are long
established it
becomes
trivialized. I have
three treasures
that I keep and
hold: one is mercy,
the second is
frugality, the third
is not presuming to
be at the head of
the world. By
reason of mercy,
one can be brave.
By

reason of frugality,
one can be broad.
By not presuming
to be at the head
of the world, one
can make your
potential last. Now
if one were bold
but had no mercy,
if one were broad
but were not
frugal, if one went
ahead without
deference, one
would die. Use
mercy in war, and
you win; use it for
defense, and
you're secure.
Those whom
heaven is going to
save are those it
guards with mercy.
up

On seeing inner
nothingness You
see it's great
beyond compare
Though many
find it curious
That you would
even care I have
three treasures
that I keep The
first is
friendliness The
second is to stay
behind The third
is wanting less
For if you'

re friendly and
you care You
can dare to do
what's needed
And if you
always stay
behind The lead
will surely be
conceded And if
you're satisfied
with less You
have everything
to give Keep
these treasures
in your heart
Then you will
truly live

Chapter 68

Good Warriors
Good warriors do not arm, good fighters don't get mad, good winners don't contend, good employers serve the

He who commands should not think that tactics, valour, and effort give victory. It is by putting oneself at the service of men that one subdues them. That is the correct procedure. It is sometimes formulated as follows: art of not struggl

Violence is not the way The greatest warriors know That treachery and anger Will not defeat the foe You

A skilful leader of troops is never oppressive with his military strength. The brave soldier is hardly very violent; The best fighter doesn't become visibly angry; he hardly loses his temper. A skilful conqueror doesn't compete with people. The great conqueror doesn't fight

A skillful leader of troops is not oppressive with his military strength. A skilful fighter does not become angry. A skilful conqueror does not compete with people. One who is skilful i

ir workers. This is called the virtue of noncontention; this is called mating with the supremely natural and pristine. up

ing (of accommodating oneself, of winning be making oneself everything to everyone); of ability to manage men; of action conforming to that of heaven. All these formulae designate the same thing. They show the greatness of the ancients. up

only win if you don't strive And gain if you do not oppose This is the certain victory Simplicity bestows

for small issues alone. The best user of men acts as though he were their inferior and puts himself below them by the virtue of not-competing. This is called the ability or capacity to use men, or matching heaven, or being suited to the highest found principle, [maybe of old]

n using men puts himself below them. This is called the virtue of non-competing. This is called the strength to use men. This is called matching Heaven, the highest principle of old. up

Chapter 69

Sayings on
Military
Operations
There are
sayings on the
use of arms: "Let
us not be
aggressors, but
defend." "Let us
not advance an
inch, but retreat
a foot." This is
called carrying
out no action,
shaking no arm,
facing no

Rather be on the
defensive than the
offensive, rather
retreat a step than
advance an inch,
are current
principles of
military art. It is
worth more to yield
than to triumph.
Prevention (of war)
through diplomacy
is worth even
more. That is the
meaning of certain
abstruse formulae
of military art, such
as: advancing
without marchin

In conflict just be
cautious And
always on your
guard Rather
than advance an
inch Instead
retreat a yard In
this way you go
along And make
your gain without
advancin

The strategists
say: "I dare not
take the
offensive but I
take the
defensive; I dare
not advance an
inch but I retreat
a foot." This
means: To
march without
formation, To
stretch one's arm
without showing
it, To confront
enemies with

enemy, wielding
no weapon. No
calamity is
greater than
underestimating
opponents. If you
underestimate
opponents,
you're close to
losing your
treasure. So
when opposing
armies clash, the
compassionate
are the ones who
win. up

g; defending
oneself without
moving an arm;
status quo without
fighting; holding on
without weapons;
and others. There
is no worse curse
than a war waged
with little or no
reason, (which is
sought-after
deliberately, and
pushed beyond
necessary limits).
He who does that,
exposes his own
goods to loss, and
causes great
mourning. up

g You deal with
the rival As your
position is
enhancing
Remember that
it's possible Your
rival just may
yield So don't
advance on such
a foe Let
differences be
healed

out seeming to
meet them, To
hold weapons
without seeming
to have them.
There is no
greater disaster
than to make
light the enemy.
Therefore when
armies are
mobilized and
issues joined,
The man who is
sorry over the
fact will win. up

Chapter 70

My Sayings Are Very Easy to Recognize My sayings are very easy to recognize, and very easy to apply. But no one in the world can recognize them, and no one can apply them. Sayings have a source, e

What I (Lao Zi) teach is easy to understand and to practice, and yet the world neither understands or practices it. My precepts and procedures derive from a superior principle and procedure, the Principle and its Virtue. The world does not recognize the Principle

Embarrassingly obvious And always near at hand It is this nothingness you see But never understand Tho

My words are very easy to understand and very easy to put into practice. Yet no one understands them; no one puts them into practice. But some of my teaching could have nature as a source, and also there's a principle-ruled ancestry in some of my words. Yes, [some of] my deeds have a lord; my deeds c

My doctrines are easy to understand and very easy to practice, But none in the world can understand or practice them. My doctrines have a source (Nature); my deeds have a master (Tao). It is because

vents have a leader. It is only through ignorance that I am not known. Those who know me are rare; those who emulate me are noble. This is why sages dress plainly, and conceal what is precious. up

which directs me, that is why it does not know me. Very few understand me. That makes my glory. It befalls me to be like the Sage who is unrecognized from amongst the common people because of his humble appearance, even though his interior is filled with jewels. up

ugh truth within is ageless Very few will ever see My face is what I give to you The jewel within is me

ould have [right] dao as sovereign. Most men don't understand this, they're unable to understand me. Few people understand me, and on this my real value depends. I am highly valued, for few understand me. The wise man wears a coarse cloth on top and carries jade underneath his dress, within his bosom.

people do not understand this that they do not understand me. Few people know me, and therefore I am highly valued. Therefore the sage wears a coarse cloth on top and carries jade within his bosom. up

Chapter 71

Knowing
Unconsciously To
know
unconsciously is
best. To
presume to know
what you don't is
sick. Only by
recognizing the
sickness of
sickness is

Knowing all and
believing that
one knows
nothing, is true
knowledge (of a
superior kind).
Knowing nothing
and believing
that one knows
everything, is the
common

You cannot
understand the
truth Claim to
know and show
you're ill Just see
that you are
missing That
truth is bare and
n

To know that you
do not know is
best. Who knows
that he doesn't
know is the
highest. To know
when one doesn't
know is best. Who
pretends to know
what he doesn't
know is
sick-minded; To
think one knows
when one doesn't
know is a sort of
malady. Pretend to
know when you
don't know - that's
a disease. He who
recognises this
disease as a disea

To know that you
do not know is
the best. To
pretend to know
when you do not
know is a
disease. Only
when one
recognizes this
disease as a
disea

it possible not to
be sick. The
sages' freedom
from ills was
from recognizing
the sickness of
sickness, so they
didn't suffer from
sickness. up

evil of humans.
Seeing this evil
as an evil, keeps
one away from it.
The Sage is
exempt from
self-conceit,
because he
dreads it. This
fear keeps him
from it. up

il Unknowing is
the final cure
When knowledge
takes its heavy
toll Pure
presence is
totality And
absence makes
you whole

se can also cure
himself of it [and
maybe not]. [One
may eventually get
free from a
disease by
recognising it for
what it is.] Who
recognises
sick-mindedness
as
sick-mindedness
can't be wholly
sick-minded, after
all. The wise man
is hardly
sick-minded if he
recognises sick
mind as sick and
also cures some
diseases. He's
hardly a sick mind.

se can one be
free from the
disease. The
sage is free from
the disease.
Because he
recognizes this
disease to be
disease, he is
free from it. up

Chapter 72

When the People
Are Not Awed by
Authority When
the people are
not awed by
authority, then
great authority is
attained. Their
homes are not
small to them,
their livelihood
not tiresome.
Just because
they

When the sense
of wonder goes
Disaster is not
far behind Don't
intrude in
people's lives
And they won't
think you are u

When the people
do not fear what
is dreadful, Then
what is greatly
dreadful will fall
upon them. Do
not reduce the
living space of
their dwellings.
Do no oppress
their lives. It is
because you do
not

do not tire of it, it
is not tiresome to
them. Therefore
sages know
themselves but
do not see
themselves.
They take care of
themselves but
do not exalt
themselves. So
they take one
and leave the
other. up

issatisfied, if one
does not wish to
become so.
(Dissatisfaction is
always voluntary,
coming from
preparing one's
situation with
another, and
having preference
for the other). The
Sage knows his
worth but does not
show it, (he does
not feel the need
to show it off). He
respects himself
but does not try to
be esteemed. He
discerns, adopting
this, and rejecting
that (after the light
of his wisdom). up

nkind The seer
sees both this
and that But
doesn't ask for
praise Finding
this immensity
With just a
simple inward
gaze

oppress them
that they are not
oppressed.
Therefore the
sage knows
himself but does
not show himself.
He loves himself
but does not
exalt himself.
Therefore he
rejects the one
but accepts the
other. up

Chapter 73

Boldness in
Daring Means
Killing Boldness
in daring means
killing; boldness
in not daring
means life.
These two may
help and may
harm. Who
knows the
reason for what
heaven dislikes?
This is why even
sages find it h

The way is very
easy Its
purposes prevail
When all is done
in silence
Intention cannot
fail Its

He who is brave in
daring will be
killed. He who is
brave in not daring
will live. Of these
two, one is
advantageous and
one is harmful.
Who knows why
Heaven dislikes
what it dislikes?
Even the sage
considers it a
difficult question.
The Way of
Heaven does not
compete, an

ard for them. The
Way of heaven
wins well without
contest,
responds well
without speech,
comes of itself
uncalled, relaxed
yet very
resourceful. The
net of heaven is
vast; the holes
are large but
don't let slip. up

net is vast and
over all With
meshes large
and wide Yet it
loses nothing
Holds everything
inside

d yet is skillfully
achieves victory. It
does not speak,
and yet it skillfully
responds to things.
It comes to you
without your
invitation. It is not
anxious about
things and yet it
plans well.
Heaven's net is
indeed vast.
Though its meshes
are wide, it misses
nothing. up

Chapter 74

If People Usually Don't Fear Death
If people usually don't fear death, how can death be used to scare them? If people are made to fear death, and you can catch and kill them when they act oddly, who w

If the people do not fear death, what is the good of trying to control them by the threat of death? If they fear death, then only capture and execute those who cause disorder, turning the others away from doing likewise. (The legalists who are lavish with the death penalty and believ

You truly are what isn't born
You need not be afraid to die Just live your life and know that you Will never lose the inner e

When the people are not afraid of death, why threaten them with death sentences? Even supposing the people are constantly afraid of death and we can seize and kill those who are unruly or vicious, who would dare to slay them? There's always the master executioner (Heaven). To kill in his stead is like thrusting oneself into he master-carpenter's place and doing his chipping for him. "He who tries it is lucky if he d

The people are not afraid of death. Why, then, threaten them with death? Suppose the people are always afraid of death and we can seize those who are vicious and kill them, Who would dare to do so? There is always the master

ould dare? There are always executioners. And to kill in place of an executioner is taking the place of a master carver. Those who take the place of a master carver rarely avoid cutting their hands. up

e it will sort everything out, are therefore wrong). The servant of death (heaven), kills, (let him do it. Let us not do his work. He alone is capable of it). The man who wants to kill may end up like those who play with the carpenter's tools, and often lose a finger in their play. up

ye You can't control what is to be In using tools you don't command Unlike the master carpenter You're bound to cut your hand

executioner (Heaven) who kills. To undertake executions for the master executioner is like hewing wood for the master carpenter. Whoever undertakes hewing wood for the master carpenter rarely escapes injuring his own hands. up

Chapter 75

People's Starvation When people are starving, it is because their governments take too much, causing them to starve. When people are hard to control, it is because of the contrivances of their governments, which

If the people are hungry, it is because the prince eats up excessive sums of money (which he extorts from them). If the people are restive, it is because the prince does too much, (indisposes them by his innovations). If the people exp

The people starve when taxes take The bulk of what they earn When leaders interfere too much They get rebellion in return The

People are hungry because rulers eat too much income, too much tax-grain. Therefore they starve, but also because of bad interference from those above. Some turn hard to rule as their rulers do too many things. That's why they're hard to keep in order. If so, the people are not very afraid of death, as they're anxious

The people starve because the ruler eats too much tax-grain. Therefore they starve. They are difficult to rule because their ruler does too many things. Therefore they are difficult to rule. The

make them hard to control. When people slight death, it is because of the earnestness with which they seek life; that makes them slight death. Only those who do not contrive to live are wise in valuing life. up

ose themselves lightly to death (in hazardous enterprises), it is because he loves life too much, (love of well-being, of pleasure, of fame). He who does nothing in order to live, is wiser than he who harms himself in order to live. up

people do not fear to die If leaders rob them of their lives But taking no more than you need You see that everybody thrives

to make a living. That's why they take death lightly in such cases. So: Those who interfere not with their living that are wise in exalting life. Maybe he who seeks only little after life can excel in making life valuable. But all that have hearts set only little on life could be superior to those who set store by life.

people take death lightly because their ruler strives for life too vigorously. Therefore they take death lightly. It is only those who do not seek after life that excel in making life valuable. up

Chapter 76

When People
Are Born When
people are born
they are supple,
and when they
die they are stiff.
When trees are
born they are
tender, and when
they die they are
brittle. Stiffness
is thus a
companion of

When a man is
born he is supple
and weak (but full
of life); he
becomes strong
and powerful, and
then he dies. It is
the same for
plants, delicate
(herbaceous) at
first, then
becoming woody
at the time of their
death. He who is
strong and
powerful is

We're soft and
supple when
we're born Hard
and rigid when
we die Living
plants are pliable
Deadwood is
brittle and dry
This wa

When man is born,
he is tender and
weak. In death he
becomes stiff and
hard. All things,
the grass as well
as trees, are
supple and soft
while alive. When
dead they become
brittle and dried.
So hardness and
stiffness very often
accompany death,
the soft and gentle
could be
companions o

When man is
born, he is
tender and weak.
At death he is
stiff and hard. All
things, the grass
as well as the
trees, are tender
and supple while
alive. When
dead, they are
withered and
dried. Therefore
the stiff and the
hard are compan

death, flexibility a
companion of
life. So when an
army is strong, it
does not prevail.
When a tree is
strong, it is cut
for use. So the
stiff and strong
are below, the
supple and
yielding on top.
up

marked for death;
he who is weak
and flexible is
marked for life.
The great army will
be defeated. The
great tree will be
cut down.
Everything that is
strong and great is
in a poorer
condition. The
advantage is
always with the
supple and the
weak. up

y life befriends
the weak But
death draws near
the strong The
hard and stiff are
bound to break
The supple
bends and goes
along

f life. The
headstrong army
will lose in battle.
They say "the
weapon that's too
hard will be
broken, the tree
that has the
hardest wood will
be cut down". Yes,
a hard tree will be
cut down. So the
hard and mighty
eventually should
be cast down; and
the soft and weak
may be set on
high.

ions of death.
The tender and
the weak are
companions of
life. Therefore, if
the army is
strong, it will not
win. If a tree is
stiff, it will break.
The strong and
the great are
inferior, while the
tender and the
weak are
superior. up

Chapter 77

The Way of Heaven The Way of heaven is like drawing a bow: the high is lowered, the low is raised; excess is reduced, need is fulfilled. T

Nature's way of doing is like the bending of a bow. For pulling on a bow you see the low go high and the high go low. Nature takes from those who have and gives to those who lack. When

Heaven's way is like the bending of a bow. When a bow is bent the top comes down and the bottom-end comes up. So too could heaven take away from those who have too much, and give to those that have not enough. Take away from those that have too much and give to those that have not enough. But this is far from man's way. He takes away from those that have not enough to offer those who alr

Heaven's Way is indeed like the bending of a bow. When (the string) is high, bring it down. When it is low, raise it up. When it is excessive, reduce it. When it is insufficient, supplement it. The Way of Heaven reduces whatever is excessive and supplements whatever is insufficient. The way of man is di

The Way of heaven reduces excess and fills need, but the way of humans is not so: they strip the needy to serve those who have too much. up

in nature takes from human beings. They fight to get it back. But if you see you have it all, you're not afraid to give away. Expecting nothing in return. It all comes back with no delay.

ready have too much. The man of dao can fool enough and spare, and next give to the whole world. So the wise man acts, but doesn't possess, accomplishes but lays claim to no credit. If he accomplishes a task, achieves an aim, he doesn't wish to reveal himself as better than others. So he seems to claim no credit. He seems to have no wish to appear superior, no desire to display excellence.

fferent. It reduces the insufficient to offer to the excessive. Who is able to have excess to offer to the world? Only the man of Tao. Therefore the sage acts, but does not rely on his own ability. He accomplishes his task, but does not claim credit for it. He has no desire to display his excellence. up

Chapter 78

The Most Flexible Thing in the World
Nothing in the world is more flexible and yielding than water. Yet when it attacks the firm and the strong, none can withstand it, because they have no way to change it. So the flexible overcome the adamant, the yielding ov

In this world there is nothing more supple and weak than water; and yet no one, however strong and powerful he may be, can resist its action (corrosion, wear, wave action); and no being can do without it (for drinking, growth, etc.). Is it clear enough that weakness is worth more than strength, that suppleness can overcome rigidity?
- Everyone agrees with

Water is so very soft It overcomes because it yields By wearing down the hardest rock It shows what power weakness wields The weak can overcome the strong The soft can overcome

There's hardly anything more yielding than [gas, air, and] water, but almost none is better in attacking the resistant and hard, There are few substitutes for it. Thus the yielding may conquer the resistant and the soft the hard. This was utilised by none I knew. Wise saying

There is nothing softer and weaker than water, And yet there is nothing better for attacking hard and strong things. For this reason there is no substitute for it. All the world knows that the weak overcomes the strong and the soft overcomes the hard.

ercome the forceful. Everyone knows this, but no one can do it. This is why sages say those who can take on the disgrace of nations are leaders of lands; those who can take on the misfortune of nations are rulers of the world. True sayings seem paradoxical. up

this; but no one acts according to it. The Sages have said: "He who rejects neither moral filth nor political evil is capable of becoming the chief of a territory or the sovereign of the empire." (He who is supple enough to accommodate himself to all that; and not a rigid and systematic person). These words are quite true, even though they offend many. up

the hard Everybody knows it's true So hold the low in high regard The seer sees serenity Where others see affliction The seer sees the inner truth Where others only see a fiction

s, "Only he who has accepted the dirt of a country can be lord of its soil-shrines: can become heaven-accepted there. Who bears evils of the country can become a king. Who takes into himself the calumny of the world serves to preserve the state." Straight words seem crooked.

But none can practice it. Therefore the sage says: He who suffers disgrace for his country Is called the lord of the land. He who takes upon himself the country's misfortunes Becomes the king of the empire. Straight words seem to be their opposite. up

Chapter 79

Harmonize Bitter
Enemies When
you harmonize
bitter enemies,
yet resentment is
sure to linger,
how can this be
called good?
Therefore sages
keep their faith
and do not

When the principle
of a dispute has
been settled
(some accessory
grievances)
always remain,
and things do not
return to the state
they were in
before, (bruises
remain).
(Therefore the
Sage never
questions it,
despite his right).
Keeping his half of
the agreement, he
does not exact the
execution (of what
is written). He who
knows how to

There's little
good in making
peace If
resentment
lingers You'll
never see an end
to blame If
everyone is
pointing fingers
It'

To allay the main
discontent, but in a
way that begets
further
discontents, can
hardly be top
successful. And to
patch up great
hatred is sure to
leave some hatred
behind; how can
this be regarded
as satisfactory? So
the wise man
keeps the
obligation of a
contract and
refrains from
blaming the other
party. H

To patch up
great hatred is
surely to leave
some hatred
behind. How can
this be regarded
as good?
Therefore the
sage keeps the
left-hand portion
(obligation) of a
contract And
does not blame
the oth

pressure others.
So the virtuous
see to their
promises, while
the virtueless
look after
precedents. The
Way of heaven is
impersonal; it is
always with good
people. up

conduct himself
after the Virtue of
the Principle, lets
his written
agreements sleep.
He who does not
know how to
conduct himself
thus, exacts his
due. Heaven is
impartial. (If it were
capable of some
partiality), it would
give advantage to
good people,
(those who act as
in C. It would
overwhelm them,
because they ask
for nothing). up

s better to be
pointing At the
peaceful and
creative place
Where you see
naught but
emptiness And
others say they
see your face

e stays where he
is and does not go
round making
claims on people.
Therefore good
people attend to
their obligations,
while those without
virtue attend to
other people's
mistakes. The way
of heaven is
impartial. It's
always with the
good man, without
distinction of
persons, to keep
the good firmly
supplied."

er party. Virtuous
people attend to
their left-hand
portions, While
those without
virtue attend to
other people's
mistakes. "The
Way of Heaven
has not
favourites. It is
always with the
good man." up

Chapter 80

A Small State Has Few People A small state has few people. It has the people keep arms but not use them. It has them regard death gravely and not go on distant campaigns. Even if they have vehicles, they have nowhere to drive them. Even if they have weapons, they have nowhere to use them.

If I were king of a little state, of a little people, I would take care to use (put in charge) the few dozen capable men that this state would contain. I would prevent my subjects from traveling, by making them fear possible accidental death so much that they would not dare climb into a boat or carriage. I would prohibit all use of weapons. As for writing and calculating, I would oblige them to

If a land is small and the people few And the rulers recognize what's needed The simple ways of courtesy Are happily and gladly heeded For people need so little To live their lives arigh

Let there be a small country with few people. Let there be ten times and a hundred times as many utensils. But let them not be used. Let the people value their lives highly and not migrate far. Even if there are ships and carriages, none will ride in them. Even if there are arrows and weapons, none will display them. Let the people again knot co

It has the people go back to simple techniques, relish their food, like their clothes, be comfortable in their ways, and enjoy their work. Neighboring states may be so close they can hear each other's dogs and roosters, but they make it so that the people have never gone back and forth. up

go back to knotted cords. Then they would find their food tasty, their clothes fine, their houses peaceful, and their manners and customs agreeable. (I would prevent curiosity and communication to the point where) my subjects would hear the noise of the cocks and dogs of the neighbouring state, but die from old age without having crossed the border and had relationships with the people there. up

t Are food and home and clothing Not enough for pure delight? Though nearby lands are close enough To hear their roosters crow The people will be so content That not a one will want to go

rds and use them (in place of writing). Let them relish their food, beautify their clothing, be content with their homes, and delight in their customs. Though neighbouring communities overlook one another and the crowing of cocks and the barking of dogs can be heard, Yet the people there may grow old and die without ever visiting one another. up

Chapter 81

True Words Are
Not Beautiful
True words are
not beautiful,
beautiful words
are not true. The
good are not
argumentative,
the
argumentative
are not good.
Knowers do not
generalize,
generalists do n

(I have finished.
Perhaps you may
find my discourse
lacks something, is
not very subtle,
and is scarcely
wise). This is
because native
frankness does not
dress itself up,
natural directness
avoids quibbling,
common sense
can dispense with
artificial eruditi

Truth need not
be eloquent And
eloquence may
not be true There
is no need to
argue When truth
is shining
through Those
who see may not
be learned The
learned may not
see To see you
merely need to
look In pure
simplicity The
seer

True words are
not beautiful;
Beautiful words
are not true. A
good man does
not argue; He
who argues is
not a good man.
A wise man has
no extensive
knowledge; He
who has
extensive
knowledge is not
a wise man. T

ot know. Sages
do not
accumulate
anything but give
everything to
others, having
more the more
they give. The
Way of heaven
helps and does
not harm. The
Way for humans
is to act without
contention.

on. The Sage does
not hoard, but
gives. The more
he does for men,
the more he can
do; the more he
gives them, the
more he has.
Heaven does good
to all, doing no evil
to anyone. The
Sage imitates it,
acting for the good
of all, and
opposing himself
to no one.

doesn't have to
hoard And does
not fear to lose
The more you
give, the more
you have So why
should you
refuse? Why not
give it all away?
For emptiness
brings benefit
And as the seers
always say The
more you give,
the more you get

he sage does not
accumulate for
himself. The
more he uses for
others, the more
he possesses of
his own. The
Way of Heaven
is to benefit
others and not to
injure. The Way
of the sage is to
act but not to
compete.